

LG clears long-pending land allotments for public projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A series of long-pending land allotment issues delaying public infrastructure and welfare projects across the Capital have been resolved following directions from Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, paving the way for the execution of projects related to security, transport, education, healthcare and civic services.

According to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), the land allotments were expedited after the LG reviewed cases that had remained pending for years because of poor coordination among Government departments. The Raj Niwas said Sandhu has consistently stressed seamless cooperation among agencies to remove bottlenecks in public projects.

Among the key clearances, land has been allotted for four new police stations at Dilkusha Bagh, Sagarpur,



Suyurpur and Kishangarh, a Forensic Science Laboratory at Narela, and Intelligence Bureau facilities at Dheerpur and Tahirpur. Land has also been earmarked for staff housing for the judiciary in Rohini and Shahdara.

To strengthen urban infrastructure, DDA allotted 20 hectares of land to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) at Sanoth for a Metro depot and another 16 hectares at Narela for a casting yard. It also allotted land for sewage treatment plants and sewage pumping stations at eight locations, besides granting 151 borewell

clearances to the Delhi Jal Board. Additional land has been provided for a sewage treatment plant at Jaunti and an underground water tank at Sangam Vihar.

In the community welfare sector, DDA said it has issued 112 no-objection certificates (NOCs) for Ayushman Arogya Mandirs and five NOCs for Atal Canteens. Community halls have also been approved for sub-registrar offices at Dwarka Sector-19 and Manglapuri.

The authority has also allocated 8.5 hectares at Holambi Kalan for an e-waste e-commerce management park. In

Ghazipur, 10 acres have been handed over to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), with another 10.4 acres allotted for expanding waste-to-energy and bio-methanisation facilities. Additionally, 24 sites have been allotted to MCD for fixed compactor transfer stations.

The education sector has also received fresh land allotments, including 22.43 acres for Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University (GGSIU), 12.69 acres for Delhi Technological University (DTU) and 1,200 square metres for the Central Sanskrit University at the Education Hub in Narela. Land has also been allotted for a Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya at Jwalapuri and government schools in Shalimar Bagh and Karawal Nagar.

Officials said the move is expected to accelerate several delayed public projects and improve coordination between departments involved in land allotment and infrastructure development across Delhi.

DDA opens online application process for developers under revised TOD policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Wednesday opened the application process for developers seeking to undertake projects under the revised Transit Oriented Development (TOD) Policy through its Online Building Permit System (OBPS), marking the operational rollout of the Capital's revamped planning framework aimed at promoting affordable housing and mixed-use development along public transport corridors.

Developer Entities (DEs) intending to develop land under the policy can now submit applications online for approval by the TOD Committee before seeking sanction of building plans through the same portal, the DDA said in a statement.

The revised policy, notified on April 6 this year, covers 207 sq km along metro, Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) and railway corridors. It also brings



nearly 80 sq km of land under Land Pooling areas, Low Density Residential Areas and unauthorised colonies within its ambit for the first time.

According to DDA, the policy introduces a single-window clearance mechanism under the TOD Committee, chaired by the vice chairman of DDA and comprising representatives of all key service agencies, to provide transparent and time-bound approvals.

Developers will no longer have to seek separate permissions from agencies such as the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Delhi Jal

Board (DJB) and Delhi Fire Services (DFS), with all approvals and charges consolidated into a single online process.

The authority has also simplified TOD-related charges by introducing a unified levy covering approvals, land-use change, additional floor area ratio (FAR), water and sewerage charges, and leasehold-to-freehold conversion, among others.

The policy seeks to encourage compact, high-density and mixed-use development around transit hubs to improve public transport usage while addressing Delhi's affordable housing

requirements. It allows TOD projects on plots as small as 2,000 square metres and permits a maximum FAR of 500 on eligible plots with an 18-metre-wide road.

DDA said at least 65 per cent of the permissible FAR has been reserved for residential use, with dwelling units of up to 99 sq m to promote affordable housing.

Of the remaining FAR, 10 per cent has been earmarked for commercial and amenity spaces, while the balance can be utilised for larger housing units, office spaces, guest houses or studio apartments.

The policy also provides for underground or elevated pedestrian walkways connecting TOD developments with metro stations to improve walkability and accessibility, while allowing enhanced FAR for public and semi-public facilities located within TOD zones.

DDA has also launched a dedicated microsite on its website containing details related to the implementation of the revised TOD policy.

Govt plans to scale EV charging stations from 9,000 to 32,000 in 4 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday chaired a high-level meeting on the new EV Policy and directed officials to develop a roadmap to expand the Capital's electric vehicle charging network. The Government is planning to expand the existing nearly 9,000 charging stations to around 32,000 over the next four years.

The Metro parking areas, DDA markets, government premises, railway stations, major malls, and spaces beneath elevated Metro corridors are identified as priority locations for establishing new charging stations.

Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh and senior officials from concerned departments attended the meeting at the Delhi Secretariat.

The Chief Minister said the expansion of the charging network cannot be limited to identifying locations alone. Ensuring an uninterrupted power supply for the smooth functioning of charging stations is equally important, she said, directing a detailed review of the power supply arrangements required and the supporting electricity infrastructure's readiness for the expected increase in demand.

She also laid special emphasis on developing solar-powered charging stations,



saying this would promote cleaner and more sustainable energy solutions alongside the grid-connected infrastructure.

The Chief Minister directed officials to prioritise fast-charging technology going forward and to convert all existing slow-charging stations into fast-charging sta-

tions in a phased manner.

Effective coordination is being established with the Delhi Development Authority, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, and Original Equipment Manufacturers. Land, parking spaces, and infrastructure available with these organisations will be utilised to accelerate the installation of sta-

tions. Officials were directed to prepare detailed action plans and begin work at the earliest in coordination with the relevant agencies.

The identification of Metro parking areas as a priority location for charging stations is significant. DMRC manages large, well-organised parking facilities at multiple stations across Delhi that already see high footfall from vehicle-owning commuters.

Placing charging points at these facilities creates a natural use case; commuters can plug in their vehicles during their working hours and collect a charged vehicle when they return, without any additional trip for the purpose of charging.

NDMC launches RRR on Wheels for collection of recyclable waste

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Wednesday launched RRR (Reduce, Reuse, Recycle) on Wheels vehicles to collect recyclable waste directly from residents' homes.

The NDMC has also released a citizen handbook on the Solid Waste Management Rules 2026, both developed in collaboration with Chintan Environmental Research and Action Group.

NDMC Chairman Keshav Chandra released the handbook and flagged off the



RRR on Wheels vehicles at a programme held at NDCC Phase-II.

The RRR on Wheels initiative extends the reduce, reuse, and recycle model beyond NDMC's existing network of eight micro-material recovery facilities across its area. It is specifically designed for residents who segregate their waste

at home but are unable to travel to a fixed RRR centre. The vehicles will visit homes to collect recyclables, e-waste, textiles, and other dry waste and channel them to authorised recyclers.

The initiative also involves trained waste-pickers in its operations and links them to formal recognition and livelihood schemes, including the NAMASTE programme, ensuring that as doorstep collection becomes more convenient for residents, the workers enabling it have more secure and dignified employment.

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client has lawfully purchased the below described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Hemlata W/o Premaraj resident Jasana Road Lingayas Collage Nachauli Village Badapur Said(111), Badapur Syed Faridabad Haryana 121101 collectively referred as "Sellers"

The details of the said land of the Seller are as under: Khawat/Khata No. 137/140 Rect. No. 47 Killa No. 15(8-0), 16(8-0), Rect. No. 48 Killa No. 11(8-0), 12(8-0), 19(6-0), 20(8-0) total fields 6 land measuring 46 Kanal 0 Marla having share to the extent of 361/963 share which comes to 17 Kanal 4.88 Marla as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2022-2023 vide Mutation No. 2387, 2399 Situated within the revenue estate of Village Ribar Tehsil Hathin, District Palwal Haryana ("Scheduled Property/Land")

The said purchase has been undertaken by my Client with due care and proper due diligence. The said Public notice is being issued, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller had further declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller had further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and was in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It was also declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land and my client shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual,vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed, sell and deal with the Scheduled Property/Land.

Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

The Scheduled Property/Land shall be deemed to include all rights, easements, pathways, appurtenances, standing crops, trees, plants, constructions, fences, boundary walls, etc. attached thereto.

The general public is hereby cautioned not to deal or enter into any transaction concerning the Schedule Property/Land with any person, party, or entity, failing which such transaction shall be at their own cost, risk and consequences.

This public notice is issued on behalf of my Client with complete bona-fide, transparency, and good faith so as to safeguard my client against any future allegations of fraud, misrepresentation, or collusion or any other allegations whatsoever in relation to the Schedule property. This notice is being issued without prejudice to any of the legal rights, contentions and remedies available to my client under applicable law

Durga Lal - Advocate, Law Consultant Office,
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Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client has lawfully purchased the below described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Madhu Bala W/o Anil Kumar resident Makan No. 534, Goga Patti, Bus Stand Ke Pass, Mandkola(217), Palwal Haryana – 121103 collectively referred as "Sellers"

The details of the said land of the Seller are as under: Khawat/Khata No. 3175/3136 Rect. No. 162 Killa No. 2(3-0), 3(8-0), total fields 2 land measuring 16 Kanal 0 Marla having share to the extent of 1/4 share which comes to 4 Kanal 0 Marla as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022 and vide Mutation No. 18277 Situated within the revenue estate of Village Mandkola Tehsil Hathin, District Palwal Haryana ("Scheduled Property/Land")

The said purchase has been undertaken by my Client with due care and proper due diligence. The said Public notice is being issued, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller had further declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller had further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and was in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It was also declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land and my client shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed, sell and deal with the Scheduled Property/Land.

Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

The Scheduled Property/Land shall be deemed to include all rights, easements, pathways, appurtenances, standing crops, trees, plants, constructions, fences, boundary walls, etc. attached thereto.

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This public notice is issued on behalf of my Client with complete bona-fide, transparency, and good faith so as to safeguard my client against any future allegations of fraud, misrepresentation, or collusion or any other allegations whatsoever in relation to the Schedule property. This notice is being issued without prejudice to any of the legal rights, contentions and remedies available to my client under applicable law

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Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client has lawfully purchased the below described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Rajpal S/o Manohar Lal resident Hayatpur (114), Garhi Harsaru Gurgaon Haryana – 122505 collectively referred as "Sellers"

The details of the said land of the Seller are as under: Khawat/Khata No. 222/1/226/1 Rect. No. 9 Killa No. 19/2(2-16), 21(3-1), 22/1(6-15), Rect. No. 20 Killa No. 2/1(2-3), total fields 4 land measuring 14 Kanal 15 Marla Salam Share as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2022-2023 and vide Mutation No. 2418 Situated within the revenue estate of Village Ribar Tehsil Hathin, District Palwal Haryana ("Scheduled Property/Land")

The said purchase has been undertaken by my Client with due care and proper due diligence. The said Public notice is being issued, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller had further declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller had further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and was in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It was also declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land and my client shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual,vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed, sell and deal with the Scheduled Property/Land.

Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

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Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client has lawfully purchased the below described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Veena Tanwar W/o Sh. Rajender Singh resident House No. D-957, 100 Foot Road, Chawla Colony, Ballabgarh, Faridabad Haryana - 121004 collectively referred as "Sellers"

The details of the said land of the Seller are as under: Khawat/Khata No. 3459/3425 Rect. No. 71 Killa No. 13/2(6-19), 17/2(1-7), 18(8-0), total fields 3 land measuring 16 Kanal 6 Marla having share to the extent of 127741/260148 share which comes to 8 Kanal 0.07 Marla as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022 and vide Mutation No. 23035 Situated within the revenue estate of Village Mandkola Tehsil Hathin, District Palwal Haryana ("Scheduled Property/Land")

The said purchase has been undertaken by my Client with due care and proper due diligence. The said Public notice is being issued, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller had further declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller had further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and was in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It was also declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

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Under-construction building collapses in Rohini, killing one

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Amid heavy downpour in the National Capital, one person was killed, and two others were rescued after an under-construction building collapsed in Rohini on Wednesday evening, triggering a massive rescue operation as seven to 10 people, reportedly, remained trapped beneath the rubble.

The collapse occurred around 4:20 pm, opposite a house near the MCD school in Sector 16, Rohini. Teams from the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), Delhi Police, the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), and other emergency response agencies rushed to the spot. They launched rescue operations, using hydraulic cutters and spe-

cialised equipment to clear the debris.

Rohini DCP Shashank Jaiswal said one person was declared dead, while rescuers could hear the voices of at least five to six people trapped beneath the collapsed structure. "The debris is extensive," the officer said, adding that, as a precautionary measure, police evacuated houses within a 50-metre radius of the site.

According to local sources, the four-storey building was old and undergoing reconstruction when it collapsed. Apart from labourers engaged in the construction work, some passersby are also believed to be trapped under the debris. Additionally, some cars parked around the now-dilapidated building are



Rescue operation is underway after a four-storey building collapsed at Rohini Sector 16 in New Delhi

reportedly trapped.

Even before specialised rescue teams reached the site, residents began clearing broken bricks, concrete slabs and mangled iron rods with their bare hands in a desperate effort to rescue those trapped beneath the rubble.

Videos circulating on social media also showed people forming human chains to pass debris along, while some fetched shovels and other tools from nearby homes and construction sites to aid the rescue efforts.

According to local sources,



PANKAJ KUMAR

nearly seven to ten people were feared trapped when rescue operations began. Two people were pulled out alive, according to PTI, while efforts continued late into the evening to reach others. DFS identified one victim as Saddham (32), who was taken

to Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital for treatment.

A video released by the DFS showed firefighters carefully removing heavy concrete slabs with hydraulic cutters to avoid causing further injury to those trapped. In the clip, a firefight-

Heavy rain floods roads, triggers massive traffic jams across Capital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Incessant torrential rains on Wednesday left large parts of the city waterlogged and traffic jammed for hours. Pedestrians were seen wading through knee-high water in low-lying areas, and long queues of vehicles formed on several stretches as movement slowed to a crawl during peak times.

The problem was compounded when many two-wheeler riders took shelter under elevated metro corridors, creating bottlenecks and hampering traffic flow.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said cumulative rainfall recorded till 8.30 am stood at 14.2 mm at Safdarjung, 19.2 mm at Palam, 17.8 mm at Lodhi Road, 54.3 mm at Ridge, 37.6 mm at Ayanaagar, 18.6 mm at Rajghat, 44.5 mm at Pusa, 85.5 mm at Najafgarh and 24.5 mm at Mayur Vihar.

Traffic congestion was also reported at the ITO intersection. Commuters faced delays on Ring Road, Outer Ring Road and National Highway 48, particularly near

Dhaura Kuan, Mahipalpur and Rajokri due to reduced visibility and waterlogging.

Vehicular movement was also affected on Mathura Road near Ashram, the Delhi-Gurugram Expressway, Zakhira flyover, Moti Nagar, Patel Nagar, Naraina, AIIMS, South Extension, Lajpat Nagar, Moolchand, Azadpur, Mukarba Chowk and stretches of the Delhi-Noida Link Road.

Civic bodies received at least 10 complaints of rain-related waterlogging, tree-fall incidents and electricity disruptions here. The MCD's Central Control Room received eight complaints between 2 pm and 6 pm, including four related to tree falls and four on waterlogging. Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Safdarjung recorded 26.0 mm of rainfall, Palam 27.9 mm, Lodhi Road 30.0 mm, Ridge 11.8 mm, Ayanaagar 22.2 mm, Rajghat 10.1 mm, Pusa 30.5 mm, Najafgarh 38.0 mm and Mayur Vihar 26.5 mm. Complaints of two tree-fall incidents were reported from the Karol Bagh zone: One near Vandan Vihar Light Flats in Paharganj and another near Shadipur Metro



Vehicles wade through a waterlogged road after heavy rainfall at Ghazipur in New Delhi

PTI

Station. One complaint each was also received from Sector 10, Dwarka, and Nangloi in the Narela zone.

Among the waterlogging complaints received by the MCD, one was reported in Shahbad Dairy under the Rohini zone, while the others were from Pocket-14 Moonlight Apartments in Sector 20, Narela, B-226, Sector 8, Dwarka, and House No. 22, Pocket 2, Sector 22, Rohini. Officials said the complaints were received through the Monsoon app and the centralised call centre and were assigned to

field officials for action.

Traffic police personnel were deployed at major intersections to regulate traffic and clear congestion, while civic agencies worked to drain water from affected stretches. Authorities advised commuters to avoid waterlogged routes, maintain a safe distance between vehicles and check traffic updates before heading out.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), which oversees the Lutyens' Delhi area, separately reported two waterlogging complaints by the afternoon.

TRAFFIC POLICE IDENTIFY 169 WATERLOGGING HOTSPOTS ACROSS CAPITAL

New Delhi: Following two days of heavy rain that triggered traffic congestion at several key stretches, the Delhi Traffic Police identified 169 waterlogging-prone traffic hotspots across the national capital and implemented a comprehensive monsoon preparedness plan.

The officer said widespread traffic snarls plagued the city over the past two days as persistent rainfall slowed vehicular movement across several arterial roads, including ITO, Rohtak Road, NH-48, Ring Road, Punjabi Bagh, and Shadipur. Low-lying areas also experienced water accumulation, which affected traffic flow during peak hours.

A senior officer said the department completed preparations before the onset of the monsoon by identifying locations that have historically experienced waterlogging and traffic bottlenecks.

"A total of 169 traffic

hotspots vulnerable to waterlogging have been identified across Delhi. Adequate traffic personnel have been deployed at these locations to ensure smooth movement of vehicles and immediate response in case of water accumulation," the officer said. He said the Delhi Traffic Police is maintaining constant coordination with civic agencies responsible for drainage and road maintenance to ensure that waterlogging is cleared at the earliest. The officer said fixed water pumps have been installed at designated vulnerable locations in coordination with the concerned agencies.

Arrangements have also been made to deploy mobile pumping units wherever required. He said all Traffic Inspectors (TIs) have been instructed to stay in touch with designated contact persons from civic agencies so that any complaint relating to waterlogging can be addressed without delay.

DU asks UG aspirants to complete CSAS preferences by July 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University officials on Wednesday urged undergraduate aspirants to carefully complete subject mapping and programme preferences on the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal by July 11.

A one-time correction window will be available from July 10 to July 11 following requests from students who made errors while filling their details, they said.

During a webinar to guide applicants through the admission process, university officials said students can seek assistance through eight helpline numbers available on the admission website, besides email support and a chatbot on the portal.

Delhi University Dean of Admission Haneet Gandhi, during the webinar, said the corresponding team will respond to queries virtually between 10 am and 5:30 pm.

Officials said admissions will be conducted for 73 undergraduate programmes offered across 69 colleges and departments, with a total of 71,624 seats avail-



able. Around 150 BA programme combinations will be available, while the detailed seat matrix has already been uploaded on the university website.

They said the undergraduate admission process comprises three phases — profile creation, subject mapping and preference filling.

The first and second phases are currently running simultaneously, and candidates have until 11.59 pm on July 11 to complete subject mapping and fill programme and college preferences, after which they will be automatically locked, the officials said.

Admissions under supernumerary categories, including sports and extracurricular activities, will also be processed based on candidates' preferences, they added.

DPCC rolls out Dust Portal 2.0 to tighten monitoring of construction-related pollution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

All construction and demolition projects will be required to submit periodic compliance reports, install air quality sensors and provide live camera feeds for real-time monitoring under the Delhi Pollution Control Committee's (DPCC) upgraded Dust Portal 2.0.

In a bid to strengthen oversight of dust pollution from construction activities, the DPCC has issued a user manual for Dust Portal 2.0, an upgraded version of its Dust Pollution Control Self-Assessment Portal.

According to the user manual of the portal, all construction and demolition projects with a plot area of 500 square metres or more are required to register on the platform, which has been developed in line with directions issued by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM).



The portal aims to digitise compliance monitoring by enabling project proponents to self-register construction sites, map site boundaries using GIS technology, submit periodic self-audit reports and upload supporting documents and photographs. It also integrates real-time monitoring of PM2.5 and PM10 levels and live video surveillance of project sites.

Under the system, registered project proponents will have to submit a self-audit assessment sheet every 15 days. The audit covers 12 compliance para-

meters, including green net coverage around sites, water sprinkling, covering of construction material stockpiles, vehicle tyre-washing facilities, anti-smog gun installation, air quality sensors, CCTV surveillance, waste disposal and worker awareness programmes.

Specifications of camera installation and setup instructions have also been issued for construction sites to comply with.

The manual warns that incomplete or delayed submissions may attract show-cause notices from the DPCC.

A key feature of the portal is GIS-based mapping of construction sites. Existing users of the earlier DPCC portal have been directed to complete a one-time migration process by digitally marking the exact boundaries of all previously registered projects before accessing the new dashboard.

The system also automatically calculates the number of anti-smog guns required at a site based on its built-up area. Projects with a built-up area between 5,000 and 10,000 square metres must install one anti-smog gun, while projects exceeding 20,000 square metres require four.

In addition, all registered construction sites are required to install PM2.5 and PM10 sensors for continuous air-quality monitoring and provide live CCTV feeds through RTSP links to enable remote surveillance by the pollution watchdog.

CM orders check on stamps duty evasion in property registrations through GPAs



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta issued strict orders on Wednesday to combat the misuse of power of attorney for evading stamp duty.

She directed that every power of attorney document executed in favour of non-blood relations must be evaluated and decided upon within 30 days by the collectors of stamps in Delhi. The move will curb revenue loss in the registration of immovable properties and also rein in land mafia and irregular practices at sub-registrar offices, the Delhi Chief Minister's Office said in a statement.

The General Power of Attorney (GPA) documents executed in favour of individuals other than blood relations, specifically parents, spouses, sons, daughters, brothers, or sisters, will no longer be directly registered by the sub-registrar.

"It has come to the notice of this Department that General Powers of Attorney (GPAs) relating to immovable properties are being presented for registration on nominal stamp duty. In several cases, such documents, though titled as GPAs, contain recitals indicating transfer of ownership rights, receipt of consideration, transfer of possession, irrevocable authority and powers to sell, transfer, gift, exchange, mortgage or otherwise permanently alienate the property," according to an order issued by the Stamp and Registration section of the Revenue Department.

The order said that no such GPA shall be registered until the speaking order of the

tender, two water bowsters, a multipurpose vehicle and an incident response team to the spot.

In a statement, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) said the area where the collapse occurred had been denotified in 2016 and handed over to the local body. It said all building activities in the denotified area are under the jurisdiction of the local civic authorities. Investigations into the cause of the collapse are underway.

Delhi has experienced heavy rainfall this week, but authorities have yet to determine the exact cause of the recent building collapse. Notably, this accident occurred a month after the Saket building collapse, which claimed six lives and injured several others.

Collector of Stamps has been received and complied with, including payment of the requisite stamp duty, wherever applicable. In a statement, the chief minister said that all such cases will be mandatorily referred to the concerned collector of stamps for adjudication to determine the appropriate stamp duty payable.

The collector of stamps will be required to pass a reasoned written order on every such reference within 30 days. The order will determine whether the document is merely a GPA or attracts full stamp duty as applicable to a conveyance deed (sale deed), she said.

In exceptional circumstances, this period may be extended up to a maximum of three months. No such GPA will be registered unless the collector of stamps has passed the order and the appropriate stamp duty has been paid, she said.

Acting on the chief minister's directions, strict guidelines have been issued for the detailed scrutiny of property-related documents executed through GPA. All sub-registrars have been directed to ensure strict compliance with these instructions with immediate effect, the CMO said.

It has been observed that in several cases, documents are registered merely as a GPA by paying only a nominal stamp duty, even though they contain provisions relating to the sale of property, handing over possession and transfer of ownership rights.

The chief minister stated that this practice represents direct evasion of stamp duty and will not be tolerated under any circumstances.

Tihar inmate Matthew VanDyke seeks American diet, cites food concerns

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In a Delhi courtroom on Wednesday, Special Judge Prashant Sharma heard an unusual request: a US citizen accused in a high-profile terror conspiracy case wanted an "American diet" while lodged in Tihar Jail. His lawyers told the court that Matthew Aaron VanDyke had been on a hunger strike for roughly 50 days, surviving mostly on soy milk and liquids because he could not stomach the spicy, oily, and deep-fried meals served to inmates in the jail.

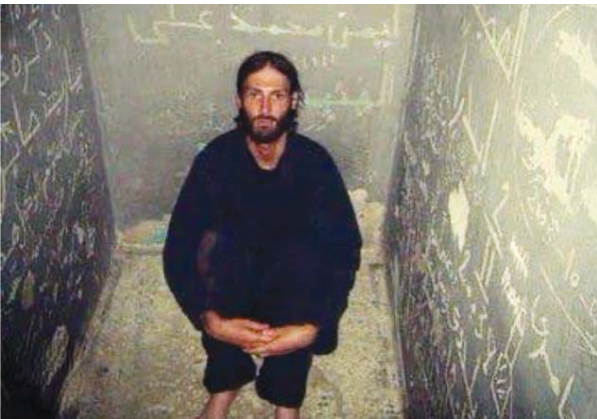
The court heard that Tihar prison officials plan to respond to the plea, but the National Investigation Agency

(NIA) chose not to comment for now. The next hearing is set for July 21. VanDyke, 47, stands out among detainees. He was born in Baltimore in 1979 and has degrees in political science and security studies. He became well known as a documentary filmmaker and international security analyst, often working in war zones. He travelled alone by motorcycle across North Africa and the Middle East, spent time with US troops, and in 2011 joined Libyan rebels fighting Muammar Gaddafi. After being captured near Brega, he spent almost six months as a prisoner of war, much of it alone in Tripoli's Abu Salim prison. He later shared his story in the film Point and

Shoot, which won Best Documentary at the Tribeca Film Festival.

Afterwards, VanDyke founded Sons of Liberty International (SOLI), a non-profit that trained fighters against ISIS in Iraq and has supported Ukraine since 2022. He says he stands against authoritarian regimes.

On March 13, 2026, India's National Investigation Agency arrested VanDyke and six Ukrainians. They are accused of using India, including Mizoram, as a route to Myanmar, where they allegedly trained ethnic armed groups in drone use and warfare. The NIA claims these groups are connected to insurgents in India's



Matthew Aaron VanDyke

Northeast. The charges fall under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), including conspiracy related to terrorism.

VanDyke and the others have been in Tihar Jail since early April. In court, he has appeared in a wheelchair, reportedly due to an injured

leg and declining health. His family and supporters are concerned about his condition, noting his poor eyesight and general weakness.

Recently, his lawyers, Rohit Dandriyal and Rohit Gour, asked the court to allow VanDyke to follow an American-style diet for humanitarian reasons. They explained that his usual eating habits and difficulty with Indian prison food have led him to a liquid-only hunger strike since May. He has reportedly been surviving on soy milk and juices, which have caused significant weight loss, weakness, and a weaker immune system.

The plea states that his family is willing to pay for the

special diet. On July 6, the court asked the NIA to respond. By Wednesday, Tihar officials said they would reply within a week.

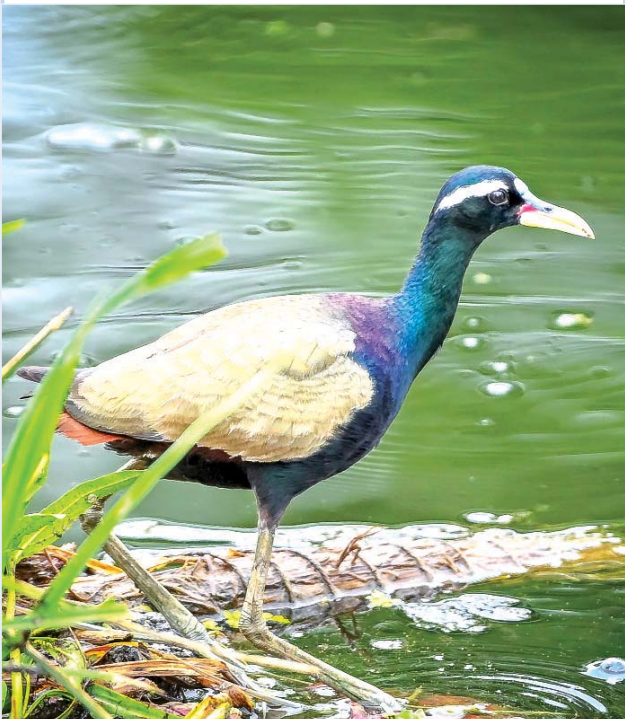
This case highlights the practical issues of housing foreign nationals with special dietary needs in Indian prisons. Indian jails often allow religious and medical diets. Still, VanDyke's request for an "American diet," likely meaning blander, protein-focused Western meals, has drawn attention because of the serious charges he faces. His lawyers say it is a basic humanitarian issue related to his health, while some critics see it as another demand from a high-profile foreign accused.

The NIA and prison officials

have not yet given a formal response. VanDyke's custody has been extended, most recently until early August. The investigation into the alleged drone-training network continues. His lawyers have also raised concerns about consular access and family communication in earlier hearings. For now, the court is deciding whether Tihar will allow a special diet for the American who once survived Gaddafi's prisons and is now struggling with Indian prison food.

With the July 21 hearing approaching, VanDyke's diet could become both a legal and humanitarian issue. His dramatic life story is now taking another turn in an unexpected place.

IN FOCUS



A bronze-winged jacana stands along the edge of a waterbody in Nadia district, West Bengal

PTI

Mamata warns rebel TMC leaders: stay with party or join the BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday attacked the dissident Trinamool Congress leaders, asking them to either remain with the TMC or openly join the BJP instead of “staying in the middle of the river”.

In a video message, Banerjee accused the rebel TMC MLAs and MPs of acting at the behest of the BJP and alleged that their “betrayal” had emboldened the saffron party to intensify attacks on Trinamool Congress workers.

Her comments came on a day when workers of the BJP and the TMC youth wing clashed in Kolkata during a protest march by the Mamata Banerjee-led party over the rape and murder of an 11-year-old girl in Baruipur, prompting police personnel to baton charge to control the situation. The rally, which was organised by youth workers of the Mamata Banerjee-aligned TMC after securing



a green signal from the Calcutta High Court, was repeatedly obstructed by BJP workers who raised “thief” slogans and even tried to set up human barricades along the protest march route along the Hazra Road.

“Those who are playing games should make up their minds. Either stay with the Trinamool Congress and work with us, or directly join the BJP. Don't remain in the middle of the

river; otherwise, you will lose both ends,” she said. Banerjee also alleged that the “traitors” have become associates of the BJP. Without naming anyone, Banerjee referred to leaders opposed to her leadership and said they should stop misleading party workers. “If you want to go, go directly to the BJP. Don't pretend to be in the Trinamool Congress while working for them,” she said.

Banerjee urged party workers not to be influenced by “traitors” and reminded them of the sacrifices made by grassroots activists who had faced violence while working for the party.

“It was with their support and sacrifice that you won,” she said.

The TMC supremo also claimed that despite court permission for the party's programmes, the police had cancelled permissions multiple times, raising questions over adherence to judicial orders. She alleged that people were being denied justice and accused the BJP of trying to disturb peace in the State.

UAV Drishti-10 crashes near Porbandar city

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Porbandar

An unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) of the Indian Navy crashed into an open field during a training sortie near Gujarat's Porbandar city on Wednesday afternoon shortly after taking off from an air enclave, but no casualties were reported, officials said.

The UAV crash-landed in an open field at Dharampur village, around 6km from the coastal city in the Saurashtra region, Porbandar District Collector S D Dhanani said.

The cause of the crash was yet to be ascertained, he added. “A UAV of the Indian Navy crash-landed near Dharampur village. No one was killed or injured in the incident. Navy personnel already reached the spot and started further investigation,” Dhanani told reporters. The officials said the UAV had



taken off from the Naval Air Enclave in Porbandar before it went down in the nearby field. Later in the evening, the Navy confirmed the crash of their UAV ‘Drishti-10’.

“Indian Navy confirms the crash of Uncrewed Aerial Vehicle Drishti-10, off Porbandar airfield during a training sortie this afternoon. NO INJURY OR LOSS OF LIFE has been reported on ground. The cause of the incident is being investigated,” the Navy said on their official X handle.

Om Prakash Vyas takes charge as Delhi Child Rights Commission Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Om Prakash Vyas assumed charge on Wednesday as Chairperson of the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights, the statutory child rights body that had remained without a full commission for nearly three years.

Vyas called on Chief Minister Rekha Gupta shortly after taking office, where he pledged that all members of the Commission are committed to working round the clock to protect children's rights, secure their future, and support their overall development.

The Chief Minister congratulated Vyas on his appointment and said she is confident the Commission under its new leadership will work with sensitivity, transparency, and accountability. She



said the Delhi Government is not merely formulating policies for child safety but is continuously working to ensure effective implementation on the ground.

She said the Commission will play a key role in making ongoing child protection efforts even more effective.

Vyas, in his remarks after assuming office, said the child protection model being developed in Delhi, as the National Capital, has the

potential to serve as an inspiration for the rest of the country. He expressed confidence that the efforts under way under the Chief Minister's leadership would establish Delhi as a strong example in child protection.

He laid out his priorities for the Commission clearly. He said the Commission will work toward ensuring effective implementation of the POCSO Act and all statutory provisions related to children's rights.

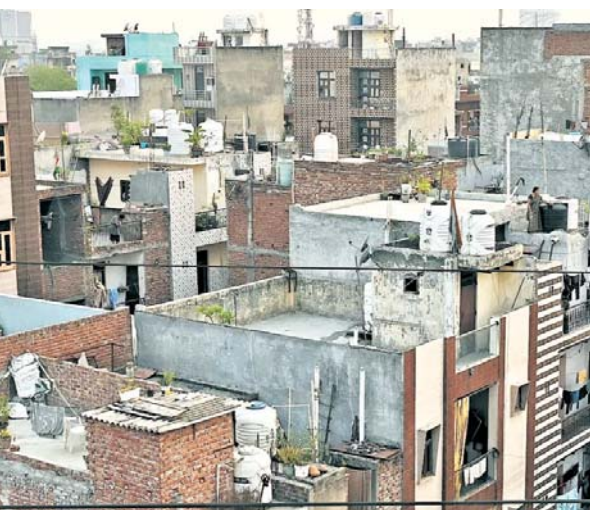
Delhi Government defines agency roles for 1,511 colonies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has issued comprehensive directions defining the responsibilities of various urban local bodies for the augmentation and maintenance of civic infrastructure in 1,511 unauthorised colonies regularised under the PM-UDAY scheme.

The directions, issued under the National Capital Territory of Delhi (Recognition of Property Rights of Residents in Unauthorised Colonies) Regulations, 2019, lay down the roles of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), Delhi Jal Board (DJB), Public Works Department (PWD) and other agencies in the regularised colonies.

“The concerned local body with territorial jurisdiction shall function as the nodal agency for planning, coordi-



inating, executing, and maintaining civic infrastructure and municipal services in unauthorised colonies regularised under PM-UDAY,” said an order on Wednesday. To facilitate coordination among departments, the Government constituted a

State-Level Coordination Committee chaired by the Delhi Chief Secretary.

According to the directions, the local body will be responsible for the development and maintenance of internal roads and streets, stormwater drainage

systems, sanitation services, solid waste management infrastructure, street lighting wherever applicable, public health-related municipal services and other functions falling within the ambit of municipal laws.

“The DJB has been tasked with developing and maintaining water supply and sewerage infrastructure, while the PWD will continue to handle the development, strengthening and maintenance of identified major roads 60 feet and above, along with connectivity corridors,” the order said.

The Government said other departments and agencies would undertake works from time to time.

The order also clarified that infrastructure projects already being executed by agencies such as the Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (DSIIDC) and the

Irrigation and Flood Control Department (I&FC) will continue under the existing arrangement until completed. “It is considered necessary, in public interest, that such ongoing works may continue on an ‘as is where is’ basis till completion. After which the completed works may be handed over to the concerned agency in accordance with applicable procedures,” the order stated.

The state-level committee will oversee inter-agency coordination, resolve implementation bottlenecks, monitor physical and financial progress, review timelines and periodically assess infrastructure development in the regularised colonies.

The order follows amendments to the PM-UDAY regulations notified in April this year and the subsequent notification regularising 1,511 unauthorised colonies.

No India role in Nijjar killing: Canada

Canadian authorities have charged four Indians in connection with the Nijjar killing, though Moreland declined to comment on the details of that parallel case.

Bilateral relations began to stabilise after Mark Carney took over as Liberal Party leader and Prime Minister in March 2025 following Trudeau's departure. Carney adopted a more pragmatic approach, separating security concerns from broader bilateral engagement.

Carney visited India in March this year for a standalone bilateral summit, while Prime Minister Narendra Modi attended the G7 summit in Canada last year, helping restore normalcy in ties. The RCMP statement is being seen in New Delhi as a long-awaited course correction that validates India's consistent position on the issue. Officials had maintained that the Nijjar case was being exploited by elements hostile to India and that criminal gangs, not state actors, were responsible.

US-Iran ceasefire crumbles as Trump...

The US said the license was revoked in retaliation for what it said were Tehran's attacks on ships in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran hit back with strikes on Bahrain and Kuwait.

US President Donald Trump said later that the interim agreement with Iran was “over” but he would allow talks to continue. That raised concerns that the wider conflict in the Middle East could resume — and oil prices shot up.

“For me, I think it's over,” Trump responded when asked about the status of ceasefire. He added that US representatives can continue negotiations but he cast doubt on the outcome. “They can talk, but I think they're wasting their time,” he said.

The crossfire came during the dayslong funeral for Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed on February 28 in the war's first moments. The funeral, which ends Thursday, was supposed to be a period of lower tensions — though mourners have repeatedly called for the killings of Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

The US military's Central Command said American forces launched strikes “to impose heavy costs for targeting and attacking commercial shipping crewed by innocent civilians in an international waterway.”

It said it hit Iranian targets including air defense systems, radars and over 60 small boats used by Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard.

Those boats have been key to threatening ships in the strait, through which a fifth of the world's traded oil and natural gas passed before the war. Iran's ability to bring shipping in the waterway to a near halt during the war proved its greatest strategic advantage as rising prices for energy supplies, fertilizer and food put pressure on the US to make a deal. On Wednesday, the price of Brent crude, the international standard, spiked over 5 per cent after Trump's comments. Iranian state media report-

ed explosions in several locations, including in Bandar Mahshahr, where a Guard member was killed. It also reported attacks on Bushehr, home to Iran's nuclear power plant complex.

On Wednesday morning, both Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, and Kuwait, home to US Army forces, sounded missile alerts. The Guard issued a statement acknowledging targeting US military installations in both countries.

A similar spate of Iranian attacks on shipping and US retaliatory strikes occurred late last month — which similarly drew Iranian attacks on Bahrain and Kuwait. Wednesday's strikes came as Trump was in Turkey for a summit of the NATO military alliance.

Before the strikes, the US revoked a license that authorized the sale of Iranian oil as part of the interim deal. That paused US sanctions and allowed Iran to conduct oil sales openly for US dollars for the first time in years. Iran long had been suspected of selling sanctioned crude at below-market prices to China.

The decision came after the strikes on shipping. One tanker was off the coast of Oman when it was hit and caught fire, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations center said. Iranian state television said the tanker came under attack after ignoring warnings but did not directly claim the assault.

Majed al-Ansari, a spokesperson for the Qatari Foreign Ministry, said the tanker was carrying Qatari natural gas and called the strike an “unacceptable attack” on international navigation and global energy security. He said Qatar, which has been a key mediator alongside Pakistan in the talks, holds Iran “fully legally responsible.”

Iran and the United States agreed as part of the interim deal to allow ships to pass through the strait without paying charges for 60 days. But Tehran has insisted it must control the vessels' routes and vowed to later charge fees for passage. That would upend decades of practice in the waterway. The ships attacked Tuesday all appeared to be using a route close to Oman's shore, rather than one ordered by Tehran.

The US and many Gulf Arab states say they will not agree to Iran charging for passage through the strait.

India to help restore Prambanan temple

India's involvement builds on its proven expertise in heritage restoration across Southeast Asia, including earlier documentation of the Borobudur Temple Compounds by the ASI.

Upon arrival at the Prambanan complex, located approximately 17 kilometres northeast of Yogyakarta city, Modi was accorded a traditional welcome. Accompanied by President Prabowo, he took a detailed tour of the ancient site, received a briefing on its history through a ceremonial panel titled 'Indonesia-India Collaborative Cultural Heritage Conservation for Prambanan Temple Compound', and unveiled a plaque commemorating the launch of the project.

“President Prabowo Subianto and I inaugu-

rated the UNESCO World Heritage Prambanan Temple Compound Restoration and Conservation Project,” Modi posted on X. “The magnificent Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of our cultural and spiritual links. Preserving such heritage is about safeguarding the traditions that continue to inspire generations.”

Modi expressed India's privilege in partnering with Indonesia. “As nations with deep cultural connections, India and Indonesia will continue to work together to celebrate our shared past while building an even stronger future,” he said.

In his address at the temple site, with the towering spires forming a majestic backdrop, Modi called the visit a “Chaitanyapurn chhann” — a moment filled with divinity. “In conversations I hear, the winds here carry a scent of culture. That scent which we feel every moment on the soil of India. This scent, this cultural heritage, connects us,” he remarked emotionally.

He thanked the people of Indonesia and its past rulers for preserving the heritage with “devotional faith” for over 1,200 years. Modi offered prayers at the temple for stronger bilateral friendship, the welfare of citizens of both countries, and rapid development of the two nations. The warmth between the leaders was palpable, seen in firm handshakes, waving to the gathering, and a concluding warm hug.

The Prambanan Temple, Indonesia's largest Hindu temple, features a sophisticated rectangular layout with outer, middle, and inner courtyards divided into higher and lower terraces. The higher terrace houses the principal shrines dedicated to Shiva, Vishnu, and Brahma, flanked by smaller temples of their animal vehicles. Intricate Ramayana reliefs adorn the inner walls of the Shiva temple, while statues of Lord Shiva, Goddess Durga, and Lord Ganesha underscore its Hindu roots.

Modi highlighted the site's significance: “In Southeast Asia, this is the second-largest identity of our heritage. For centuries, people have offered worship at this temple, and today I, too, had the fortune to visit this temple and offer prayers.” Experts see the high-profile visit and joint project as a strategic move by New Delhi to elevate cultural diplomacy in its Act East policy framework. With strong people-to-people and historical linkages, the conservation effort is expected to boost tourism, particularly from India, and deepen bilateral cooperation in heritage preservation.

India has reiterated that its support reflects an “enduring commitment to preserving shared civilisational heritage.” As work begins, the project promises not only physical restoration of the magnificent spires and sculptures but also the strengthening of a civilisational partnership that continues to inspire both nations in the 21st century.

Ram temple trust tightens purse strings

The trust says this change, which takes effect immediately for all SBI accounts, is part of wider efforts to restore public trust.

Krishna Mohan, who leads the committee, is a 73-year-old retired Indian Forest Service officer from Maharashtra. He comes from Chandrapur village in Hardoi district, Uttar Pradesh, and has been involved with the Ram Janmabhoomi movement and the RSS. Known as a quiet organiser, Mohan was recently made a trustee by unanimous decision. He is now in charge of daily administration until a permanent general secretary is chosen.

Chandan Rai, serving on the committee, brings financial expertise. While Afale, an IIT-trained engineer who has played a key role in the temple's construction from the start, helps ensure financial decisions align with the needs of construction and maintenance of the temple. The cost of the temple has exceeded several thousand crores, since its inception, with the majority allocated to construction, capital works and fixed deposits. While the SIT continues its detailed re-audit of the past five years' accounts, including construction expenditure and in-kind donations such as jewellery, the new committee is presented as a step toward greater transparency and accountability.

Mahadev Book kingpin held in Oman

Chandrakar was briefly detained in the UAE in October 2024 after an Interpol Red Notice and placed under house arrest. Although an extradition request was made, it was unsuccessful. He escaped again but was caught recently in Oman while attempting to enter the country using a fake passport.

Chandrakar, who ran a chain of juice shops in Bhilai, built Mahadev Online Book with his associate Upaal in 2018-19, turning it into one of India's biggest illegal online betting networks in a short time before moving to Dubai. The platform allowed bets on sports like cricket, football, tennis, badminton, poker, card games, and even election results, all of which break Indian gambling laws.

From Dubai, they operated mainly through a franchise model, opening branches in Indian cities under a 70-30 profit split. Users joined, betting IDs were created, and money was moved through fake bank accounts and *hawala* channels. At its peak, the operation reportedly generated ₹200-240 crore per day. The ED estimates the total proceeds of crime at about ₹6,000 crore. Chandrakar and Upaal reportedly lived in luxury in the UAE, renting several villas for their staff. A lavish wedding in the UAE, reportedly costing crores in cash, also drew attention. The Mahadev case became a national scandal because of alleged links to top politicians and bureaucrats in Chhattisgarh.

Upaal, is still missing. He was held in Dubai for a short time in December 2023 following an Interpol Red Notice before being released soon after. In November 2025, UAE authorities informed Indian agencies that Upaal had left the country. Investigators think he went to Vanuatu, a country that does not have an extradition treaty with India. Reports say he may have Vanuatu citizenship or a passport. In November 2025, the Supreme Court told the ED to find and secure him, stating that kingpins

cannot treat courts and investigating agencies as “mere instruments to play around with.”

LeT commander killed in J&K

Early Wednesday morning, the security forces tracked down the hiding LeT terrorist and neutralised him while searches were going on to track down his accomplice. The Army's specialised counter-insurgency unit, Victor Force, had deployed additional personnel to seal all possible escape routes through the thick orchard foliage, besides lighting up the area.

“You Can Run But You Can't Hide ! One Lashkar terrorist neutralised by SOG Shopian, in a Jt Op, along with RR and CRPF,” the Jammu and Kashmir Police said in a post on X.

The slain terrorist has been identified by the Srinagar-based Chinara Corps as Zakir Ahmad Ganie, a self-styled commander of the proscribed LeT outfit. Ganie (26), a resident of Motalhama area of the neighbouring Kulgam district, had on September 27, 2023 left his residence for Dialgam to undertake shuttering work but failed to return home, the officials said. They said after an unsuccessful search by his family members, a missing report was lodged at Kulgam police station on October 3, 2023.

Officials claim, Ganie subsequently joined The Resistance Front (TRF) terror outfit, an offshoot of the LeT. They said he has been implicated in an FIR registered at Kulgam police station under various sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). Meanwhile, the Anantnag police apprehended three Over Ground Workers (OGWs) through the Facial Recognition System on Wednesday. According to a police spokesman, the Facial Recognition System (FRS) installed by Anantnag Police generated timely alerts regarding three suspicious individuals while they were passing through the Sarbal area, who were subsequently arrested.

Corbett's wildlife pays the price for growing...

Loud music, high-intensity lighting and overnight vehicular movement are also said to be disturbing wildlife in the surrounding forest areas.

Wildlife experts believe it is essential to maintain a balance between tourism and environmental conservation in ecologically sensitive areas like Corbett. They warn that if regulations are not enforced strictly, the long-term impact could affect both wildlife conservation and the region's natural identity. Corbett director Saket Badola said that people visiting the region solely for partying and obscene activities are not in keeping with the true spirit of tourism in Corbett. He said it is the responsibility of resort owners and operators not to permit such unethical activities and to ensure that tourism remains responsible and respectful. He also stated that the Corbett administration has been taking consistent action against resorts violating norms related to late-night DJ systems and high-intensity lighting.

NIA searches 20 sites across 10 States in terror probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In a major crackdown on online extremism, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday carried out coordinated searches at 20 locations across 10 states and Delhi, uncovering an alleged conspiracy to radicalise vulnerable youth and push for an Islamic state through violent jihad.

According to the NIA, the accused and their associates were allegedly indoctrinating young people nationwide by sharing violent jihadi content and misinformation. The operation also revealed that the accused maintained online contact with foreign handlers to spread jihadi ideology and advance an alleged anti-India conspiracy.

The searches, conducted as part of an ongoing investigation, targeted premises in

Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Bihar, Rajasthan, Gujarat and the national capital. NIA teams seized multiple digital devices, including phones, laptops and storage media, which are now undergoing forensic scrutiny to trace communications, propaganda material and recruitment trails.

The conspiracy, the agency said, aimed at establishing an Islamic state in India by promoting violent jihad against the democratically elected Government. The accused allegedly used the internet to share graphic videos, religious interpretations and false narratives intended to fuel anger and alienation among the youth.

The NIA's preliminary findings indicate that the accused and their associates created online echo chambers, where



young people were gradually exposed to extreme content. Misinformation about Government policies, communal issues and global events was used to portray India as an enemy of Islam, pushing impressionable minds toward radicalisation.

The accused were in regular online contact with handlers based abroad, who

allegedly provided ideological guidance, propaganda material and instructions to expand the network inside India. These handlers, linked to ISIS and AQIS ideologies, used encrypted platforms to stay in touch, coordinate activities and direct the dissemination of jihadi content.

The NIA described the module as a case of hybrid

terrorism, where technology bridges the gap between local sympathisers and overseas masterminds. By using social media, messaging apps and dark web channels, the network sought to bypass traditional surveillance and reach youth in both urban and semi-urban areas across states.

The nationwide sweep reflects the growing sophistication of terror outfits that have shifted focus from physical training camps to digital indoctrination. The seizure of devices is expected to yield evidence, chat histories, deleted files, financial trails and links to other modules, once forensic experts complete their examination.

Security experts note that online radicalisation poses a challenge because it often occurs without physical meetings. The NIA's operation demonstrates how central

agencies are adapting by combining intelligence inputs with swift, multi-state action. While the investigation is still in its early stages, the NIA has said it will pursue every lead to dismantle the network completely. The agency is also examining whether the accused received any material or logistical support from their foreign contacts.

"This case serves as a reminder of the evolving threat landscape. As digital spaces become a battleground for extremist ideologies, proactive policing and public awareness remain strong shields. The NIA's operation is aimed at sending a strong message that India will not allow any group, domestic or foreign-backed, to influence the minds of its youth or challenge its democratic foundations", an official said.

States Focus



BENGALURU'S 2ND AIRPORT TO COME UP IN SOUTH OF CITY: CM

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday said the city's second airport, planned to decongest Kempegowda International Airport, will come up in South Bengaluru. He said officials have been asked to submit a proposal to the Central Government after considering a location where land cost is low, which is technically feasible, and not too hilly. The CM chaired a meeting with Minister for Infrastructure Development MB Patil and top officials regarding the second airport near Bengaluru. "We asked to ensure that no villages are disturbed and villagers should not be displaced," Shivakumar told reporters. (PTI)



IAF CHIEF REVIEWS OPERATIONAL PREPAREDNESS IN LADAKH

The Chief of the Air Staff, Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh, on Wednesday concluded his six-day visit to forward areas in the Ladakh sector, during which he reviewed the operational preparedness of the IAF units and interacted with troops deployed in high-altitude areas. Air Chief Marshal Singh, accompanied by Sarita Singh who is the president of the Air Force Families Welfare Association, visited the sector from July 3 to July 8, a public relations officer (PRO) said. The IAF chief was received at Air Force Station Leh by Air Vice Marshal Anand Sondhi and other senior officers. (PTI)

Online NEET-UG to be spread over at least 6 days from next year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The NEET-UG medical entrance exam, which is set to be conducted as a computer-based test from next year, will be spread over at least six days across more than 1,000 centres, sources said. National Eligibility Entrance Test (NEET)-UG is the largest undergraduate entrance exam in the country, with nearly 25 lakh candidates appearing for the crucial test.



adding that a detailed plan is still being firmed up. The National Testing Agency (NTA) conducts NEET every year for admission into medical colleges. A total of 1,08,000 seats are available for the MBBS course.

Of the seats available for the MBBS course, approximately 56,000 are in government hospitals and about 52,000 in private colleges. Admissions to undergraduate courses in Dentistry, Ayurveda, Unani, and Siddha also utilise the results of the NEET for admission.

The idea of switching to CBT mode for NEET is not new and has been deliberated several times before.

DRDO successfully tests long-range Pinaka rocket

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Research & Development Organisation (DRDO) conducted a successful flight test of Pinaka Long Range Guided Rocket (LRGR) at the Integrated Test Range (ITR), Chandipur on Wednesday, the defence ministry said.

Giving details, it said the rocket was tested for a user-defined minimum range of 60 kms. Demonstrating all in-flight manoeuvres as planned, the LRGR impacted on the target with textbook precision, exactly following the predicted trajectory. All the deployed range instruments tracked the flight throughout its trajectory.

The Pinaka LRGR rocket is designed by Armament Research and Development Establishment in association with High Energy Materials Research Laboratory, with support from Defence Research and Development Laboratory and Research Centre Imarat.



The flight trial was coordinated by ITR and Proof & Experimental Establishment. The rocket was launched from the in-service Pinaka launcher, demonstrating its versatility and providing launch capability of Pinaka variants of different ranges from the same launcher.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has congratulated the DRDO, the Indian Army and the industry on the successful flight test.

Don't defame Lord Ram: Mamata attacks BJP after street clash

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Invoking Ram Temple controversy for the first time, former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday said "Ram ka naam Badnam na karo" (don't defame Lord Rama).

This even as an angry Trinamool Congress chief (Kalighat faction) lambasted the Bengal BJP Government for trying to gag the Opposition voice by "unleashing its goons on their peaceful rallies."



erupted between the BJP and TMC cadres, who fought pitched battles at noon on Wednesday along the Hajra Road, leaving several persons from both sides injured. The police and the central forces had a difficult time controlling the crowd.

The members of the pro-Mamata TMC group had

organised a rally against atrocities on women in Bengal when they got embroiled in a skirmish with members of the BJP who had taken a counter rally along the same route.

Men from both the rallies were seen exchanging fisticuffs a few hundred metres from Banerjee's Kalighat house.

Air India plane tyres burst after near-miss at Mumbai Airport

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

A potentially catastrophic runway incursion was narrowly averted at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport on the night of July 7 after an Air India flight bound for Delhi aborted its takeoff following an urgent instruction from Air Traffic Control (ATC), which alerted the crew that another aircraft was still on the active runway.

According to operational logs and airport sources, Air India flight AI816 (registration VT-ALT), carrying 225 passengers and crew, had begun its takeoff roll from Runway 27 after pushing back from the bay at 2129 hrs. At approximately 2150 hrs, ATC instructed the cockpit crew to "STOP IMMEDIATELY" as the preceding arrival, Air India Express flight IX1547, had not yet vacated the runway.

The flight crew, led by Captain N Vinay Divakar, carried out a high-speed rejected takeoff in accordance with standard safety



Representative image

procedures and safely vacated the runway. Simultaneously, another inbound aircraft, AI699, was instructed to execute a go-around as a precaution.

The aircraft subsequently returned to Stand S2, reaching the bay at 2215 hrs. A runway inspection conducted between 2154 hrs and 2158 hrs found no abnormalities or foreign object debris.

However, a post-incident technical inspection revealed that three tyres on AI816 had burst during the high-speed aborted takeoff due to the

extreme braking forces involved. Air India personnel were informed of the tyre damage at around 2220 hrs. No injuries were reported among passengers or crew.

In a statement, Air India confirmed the sequence of events, saying the crew discontinued the takeoff after receiving instructions from ATC and returned the aircraft to the bay for mandatory technical inspections. The airline said alternative travel arrangements were being made for affected passengers and reiterated that pas-

senger safety remains its highest priority.

The aircraft involved was operating the Mumbai-Delhi service, while the arriving aircraft that had not cleared the runway was an Air India Express plane operating from Bagdogra. Initial reports had suggested the flight originated from Kochi, but operational records confirmed Siliguri as its departure point.

The incident is the second reported serious ground safety event involving Air India aircraft within a month. In late June, an Air India aircraft and an IndiGo aircraft reportedly came into close proximity on the ground at Ahmedabad, raising broader concerns over runway and ground movement safety.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) and the Airports Authority of India (AAI) have initiated a joint investigation into the incident. The probe will examine runway occupancy management, ATC communication protocols, and operational procedures to determine why the arriving

aircraft had not vacated the runway before takeoff clearance was issued and whether procedural or workload-related lapses played a role.

The Air India plane, understood to be around 16 years old, has been grounded pending detailed engineering inspections, including examinations of its braking system, landing gear, tyres and associated assemblies. While only the tyre damage has been confirmed publicly, engineers are also assessing the aircraft for any potential brake or engine stress resulting from the rejected takeoff.

All passengers were safely deplaned and are being accommodated on alternative flights.

The incident has once again drawn attention to the operational pressures at one of India's busiest airports and underscores the critical importance of strict runway separation and air traffic management standards. Further details are expected as the official investigation progresses.

Counter fake narratives fiercely: CEC to poll officials



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Wednesday cautioned poll officials over the rising tide of false narratives on social media, urging them to proactively counter the spread of misinformation.

Addressing the officials, he emphasised that passive monitoring is no longer enough.

He stated that administrative teams must engage swiftly to neutralise fake news before it distorts public perception.

Rajasthan Govt ties up with International Solar Alliance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

The Rajasthan Government on Wednesday tied up with the International Solar Alliance (ISA) for an action framework to accelerate the State's transition towards clean energy through grid modernisation and solar power integration.

Rajasthan is the first state in the country to enter this partnership, according to a release.

The framework, titled "Advance Clean Energy, Driven Sustainable Development", was signed in the presence of Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma at the chief minister's residence. The agreement was signed by Energy Secretary Arti Dogra and ISA Director General Ashish Khanna.

The framework will help prepare an energy transi-



Representative image

tion plan for 2030-35, focusing on renewable energy expansion, strengthening transmission and distribution infrastructure, grid modernisation, energy storage, energy efficiency, demand management, policy reforms and institutional capacity building, the release said.

The initiative will also promote artificial intelligence-enabled digitalisation in the power sector.

A pilot project based on digital twin technology will be launched in Ajmer

DISCOM to improve electricity demand forecasting, network planning, renewable energy integration and the reliability of power supply.

The chief minister said that the partnership would accelerate Rajasthan's transition towards renewable energy and help prepare a comprehensive plan for the expansion, transmission and distribution of solar power, leading to improved electricity supply and better quality power for consumers.

SIT finds proof against 8 in Ram temple donation row: Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

On Wednesday, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said the Special Investigation Team (SIT) investigating the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple had found evidence against eight people out of nearly 150 involved in counting offerings. He added that the actions of a few should not tarnish the reputation of the entire Temple Trust.

Chief Minister accused the Congress and the Samajwadi Party of trying to harm Ayodhya's reputation because of this case.

While defending the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, Adityanath said at an event in Chitrakoot that after the case came to light, opposition parties became active and used it as a chance to criticise Ayodhya.

"You must have heard the recent reports. Congress and the Samajwadi Party suddenly became active. These are parties that have historically criticised Ayodhya, and they found an issue to exploit," he told the gathering in Chitrakoot.

The chief minister said the Trust informed the government that it had received reports of alleged theft during the counting of donations and asked for



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath interacts with school children during his visit to an exhibition stall at Trade Facilitation Centre (TFC) in Varanasi on Wednesday

PTI

a high-level SIT to be formed.

"We accepted the Trust's recommendation and set up a high-level SIT. The investigation found evidence against six people directly involved in the theft and two others who were part of the conspiracy. Based on the SIT's recommendations, the Trust filed an FIR, and action was taken," he said.

He pointed out that about 150 people count offerings at the temple, but the alleged wrongdoing was

limited to a small group. He urged devotees and citizens to stay alert to such incidents.

Questioning the Opposition's criticism, Yogi Adityanath said, "When action has been taken against the accused, what is the justification for defaming the entire Trust, questioning Ayodhya and insulting the legacy of Lord Ram? It appears the Congress and the Samajwadi Party have taken a contract to attack India's faith."

■ States Focus ■



80% SIR ENUMERATION FORMS DISTRIBUTED: KARNATAKA CEO

Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar on Wednesday said that the process of the SIR was underway and that 80.85 per cent of the enumeration forms had already been distributed to electors across the State. A door-to-door house enumeration exercise under the SIR of the electoral rolls began on June 30, as per the directions of the ECI, and will continue till July 29. Addressing a press conference, Anbukumar said, "We will be distributing the enumeration forms to every house in Karnataka, to every voter. In that process, 80.85 per cent of the enumeration forms have already been distributed to electors in Karnataka." Listing the figures, he said that Chitradurga district had achieved 98.95 per cent distribution as of 2 pm on Wednesday. (PTI)



VP TO LAUNCH DEEP SEA FISHING PERMIT SYSTEM IN ODISHA

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan will launch the Letter of Authorisation (LoA) for sustainable harnessing of fisheries in the high seas and Odisha Deep Sea Mission document during his visit to Bhubaneswar on Thursday, officials said. The Vice President is scheduled to arrive here on Thursday morning on a one-day official visit. He will launch the two programmes during an event, which will be attended by Odisha Governor Hari Babu Kambhampati, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, Union Ministers Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Dharmendra Pradhan, SP Singh Baghel and state minister Gokulananda Mallik. Radhakrishnan will distribute LoA to the fisheries cooperative societies including National Cooperative Exports Limited (NCEL) and fishing vessel owners, enabling eligible Indian-flagged fishing vessels to undertake regulated fishing operations in the high seas, an official statement said. The letter of authorisation is a mandatory provision under the guidelines for sustainable harnessing of fisheries in the high seas by Indian-flagged fishing vessels, 2025, it said. Designed as a transparent and accountable framework for Indian-flagged vessels undertaking fishing or fishing-related activities in the high seas, the LoA facilitates ease of compliance for fishermen and vessel operators. (PTI)

BJP hails PM's Indonesia visit as strategic breakthrough

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Indonesia as a "major strategic breakthrough" after the two countries agreed to jointly develop the strategically located Sabang Port. The party also accused previous Congress Governments of failing to leverage India's geographical advantage in the Indo-Pacific.

India and Indonesia on Tuesday agreed to jointly develop the strategically located Sabang Port, which overlooks the Strait of Malacca and is about 160 kilometres away from India's Great Nicobar Port project. Reacting to the development, BJP IT department head Amit Malviya said the agreement, along with the Great Nicobar Transshipment Port project, will significantly strengthen India's strategic footprint in the Indo-Pacific. "Prime Minister Narendra



BJP IT department head Amit Malviya

Modi's visit to Indonesia has delivered a major strategic breakthrough. India and Indonesia will jointly develop Sabang Port in Aceh, near the Strait of Malacca, one of the world's busiest and most consequential maritime chokepoints," Malviya said in a post on social media. "Together with Great Nicobar Transshipment Port, this will significantly strengthen India's strategic footprint in Indo-Pacific and create powerful operational synergies across the region," he said.

The BJP leader said the Strait of Malacca carries nearly one-third of global trade and serves as the principal maritime artery for East Asia, including the overwhelming majority of China's energy imports and commercial shipping. "A credible presence around this sea lane translates into enormous geopolitical and economic leverage," he said. Targeting the Congress, Malviya alleged that despite India's "unmatched geo-

graphical advantage" through the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, successive Congress Governments failed to capitalise on the strategic opportunity.

"Instead of investing in world-class maritime infrastructure, strengthening India's position around the Malacca Strait and leveraging geography into national power, decades were lost to strategic indecision and neglect," he alleged.

Malviya claimed that under Modi, India is charting a different course now by converting its geographical advantage into strategic power.

"From the Great Nicobar mega transshipment project and the strengthening of the Andaman and Nicobar Command, to SAGAR and now the joint development of Sabang Port with Indonesia, Prime Minister Modi has transformed India's maritime outlook from passive observation to proactive leadership," he said.

Unions call for protests against NFSA amendments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Four major mass organisations on Wednesday jointly called for nationwide protests against the Centre's proposed amendments to the National Food Security Act (NFSA), which they claimed would drastically reduce ration quotas and severely threaten food security for the country's poorest populations.

The joint call was issued by the All India Agricultural Workers' Union (AIAWU), All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA), All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS), and the Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU). The bodies are protesting a proposal by the Department of Food and Public Distribution to alter the current ration allocation from a fixed 35 kg per household to 7 kg per person, while retain-



ing a maximum cap of 35 kg per household.

In a joint statement, the unions strongly condemned the National Food Security Amendment Bill, terming it an "anti-people move" that exposes the Government's apathy towards the working class. They argued that the proposed restructuring would end up penalising larger families. Under the new rules, any household with more than five members would see its per capita allocation drop significantly below the promised 7 kg

mark due to the rigid 35 kg household ceiling.

The organisations pointed out that nearly 236.9 lakh Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) households — comprising roughly 939.4 lakh individuals — rely entirely on these subsidised foodgrains for daily survival. This highly vulnerable demographic includes landless agricultural labourers, traditional artisans, unorganised sector workers, Dalits, Adivasis, widows, and persons with disabilities.

Citing expert consensus,

the statement noted that medical professionals and nutritionists have long maintained that marginalised populations require more than the current baseline to sustain healthy lives. The unions highlighted that historical benchmarks from the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) previously recommended at least 14 kg of foodgrains per person for proper physical development.

The joint front also criticised the reliance on outdated data, noting that public distribution system (PDS) quotas remain tethered to the 2011 Census despite significant population growth over the last decade and a half. Citing a 2021 study by prominent economists, the unions stated that over 100 million eligible individuals are already excluded from the PDS network.

Navi Mumbai Airport cleared for drug imports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union health ministry has recently inaugurated Navi Mumbai Airport in Maharashtra as a port for the import of drugs under the Drugs Rules, 1945, in a move aimed at strengthening the pharmaceutical supply chain and facilitating ease of trade, an official statement said on Wednesday.

The amendment to Rule 43A of the Drugs Rules, 1945, now includes Navi Mumbai in the list of airports through which drugs may be imported into the country, according to the statement issued by the ministry.

The gazette notification was issued after consultation with the Drugs Technical Advisory Board under the provisions of the Drugs and



Cosmetics Act, 1940, officials said. With the latest addition, the total number of notified ports of entry — across air, sea, road and rail — for the import of drugs has increased to 42, it said.

The amendment is expected to facilitate smoother movement of pharmaceutical consignments, strengthen logistics infrastructure, and provide greater flexibility to

importers by adding a new alternative for the import of medicines into India, the statement said.

The initiative is in line with the Government's continued efforts to strengthen the regulatory framework, improve trade facilitation, and promote Ease of Doing Business while ensuring effective regulatory oversight of imported drugs, it added.

465 farmer suicides recorded in Marathwada region in 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

As many as 465 farmers committed suicide between January and June 2026 in the Marathwada region of central Maharashtra with Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar district reporting the highest cases at 109, an official report said on Wednesday.

In 2025, as many as 1,131 farmer suicide cases were registered with the administration in the region, which consists of eight districts.

In the current year, from January to June, Marathwada registered 465 farmer suicide cases, a report from the Divisional Commissioner office based in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar said. The



Representative image

highest number of farmer suicides were recorded in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar district at 109, while the lowest was in Latur district (26), it said.

According to the report, 215 suicide cases were found eligible for financial aid from the Government, while 26 were found unfit for compensation.

Currently, 222 cases are under scrutiny, and financial aid has been granted in 108 cases so far.

District-wise farmer suicides from January to June are as follows: Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (109), Beed (95), Dharrashiv (65), Nanded (61), Jalna (40), Parbhani (34), Hingoli (35) and Latur (26), the report added.

ED raids 11 locations connected to ex-SP MLA Deep Narayan



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Lucknow

On Wednesday, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) searched 11 locations across Uttar Pradesh as part of a money-laundering investigation involving former Samajwadi Party (SP) MLA Deep Narayan Singh Yadav and his associates. According to officials, nine of these places were in Jhansi district, and two were in Lucknow.

The searches, carried out under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, focused on homes and businesses linked to the former legislator, his family, and related entities. Deep Narayan Singh Yadav, also called Deepak Yadav or Deepak Dadda, was the MLA for the Garutha assembly seat in Jhansi from 2007 to 2017 on an SP ticket.

The ED investigation began after an Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) was filed, based on a First Information Report (FIR) from the Uttar Pradesh Vigilance Establishment. The vigilance case claims that Yadav had assets beyond his known sources of income, along with 23 other complaints. Early findings by the ED suggest that money from alleged crimes was moved through a network of companies and Limited Liability Partnerships (LLPs) involved in real estate, construction, and other businesses.

The ED is reviewing financial transactions, beneficial ownership, and the acquisition of assets suspected to be linked to illegal activities.

During the searches, the ED seized documents, digital devices, and records related to properties and financial dealings. These materials will be further examined to trace the flow of the alleged illegal funds. Reports indicate that nearly 60 cases have been registered against him, including charges of cheating, forgery, extortion, attempted murder, and dacoity under the Indian Penal Code (IPC).

Additional cases have been registered under the Uttar Pradesh Gangsters and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act and the Goondas Act. Earlier, the Uttar Pradesh Police had attached properties worth approximately ₹130 crore in Jhansi district under the Gangsters Act.

The ED investigation is ongoing, and no arrests have been made yet in connection with Wednesday's raids. The agency will continue to investigate the financial trail and any possible links to offences under the PMLA to determine the full extent of the alleged financial misconduct. More information may come out as the investigation continues and documents are reviewed. As of late Wednesday evening, the former MLA had not made any public statement about the raids.

Political observers believe these recent actions will strengthen the fight against corruption and send a strong message that no individual is immune to investigation, regardless of their past political position or social status.

Assam Govt says only 196 of 36,358 foreigners repatriated since 2021

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Over 36,000 people have been declared foreigners in the five years since 2021, and only 196 of them have been repatriated to Bangladesh so far, the Assembly was informed on Wednesday.

In a written reply to a query by Congress MLA Mohibur Rohman, Border Protection and Development Minister Atul Bora said a total of 36,358 persons have been declared foreigners by the Foreigners Tribunals (FTs) since 2021 to May 2026. "Out of them, 196 people have been repatriated to Bangladesh from Assam," he added. Giving year-wise breakdowns, Bora said 7,151 foreigners were declared



Atul Bora

in 2021, followed by 9,028 in 2022, 6,859 in 2023, 6,178 in 2024, 5,106 in 2025 and 2036 in 2026 so far.

As per legal provisions, only the Foreigners Tribunals can declare a person a foreigner in Assam, and subsequently, higher courts can be approached if the verdict is not favourable. According to the Assam Accord, the names of all foreigners coming to Assam on or after March 25, 1971, would be detected, deleted from the electoral rolls, and steps would be taken to deport them.

Higher education enrolment rises by over 1 crore since 2014: Govt's AISHE report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The enrolment in higher education increased by over 1.08 crore since 2014 with 42 per cent increase in female enrolment, according to central Government's AISHE report.

The Ministry of Education on Wednesday released the Reports of the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) for the years 2022-23 and 2023-24.

The AISHE collects detailed information from Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) across the country through a web-based Data Capture Format (DCF). Institutions upload data on student enrolment, faculty and staff, infrastructure, examination results etc. on the AISHE portal.

AISHE serves as the primary source of official statistics on higher education in India and provides critical insights



for policy formulation, planning and monitoring of the sector.

The participation of HEIs in 2022-23 was 56,180 out of 60,380 HEIs registered and 59,533 out of 64,756 registered HEIs in 2023-24. "The enrolment in higher education has been continuously increasing from 3.42 crore in 2014-15 to 4.46 crore in 2022-23 and 4.50 crore in 2023-24 (i.e. 31.5

per cent increase since 2014-15)," the report said.

"It is commendable increase in female enrolment in higher education from 1.57 crore in 2014-15 to 2.18 crore in 2022-23 and 2.24 crore in 2023-24 (42.2 pc increase since 2014-15)," it added.

The enrolment of SC students has increased to 69.72 lakh in 2023-24 from 46.07 lakh in 2014-15 (an increase of

51.4 per cent since 2014-15). "The enrolment of ST students has increased to 28.83 lakh in 2023-24 from 16.41 lakh in 2014-15 (an increase of 75.7 per cent since 2014-15). Similarly, the enrolment of Other Backward Classes (OBC) students has increased to 1.80 crore in 2023-24 from 1.13 crore in 2014-15 (60.2 per cent increase)," it added.

STEM enrolment has risen significantly over the past decade, from 91.5 lakh in 2014-15 to 1.02 crore in 2023-24, reflecting the growing emphasis on science, technology, engineering, and mathematics education in the country.

"The total number of faculty increased to 17.32 lakh in 2023-24, of which 55.1 pc are male and 44.9 per cent are female. The female faculty strength has increased from 5.69 lakh in 2014-15 to 7.37 lakh in 2022-23 and further to 7.78 lakh in 2023-24," it said.

Namami Gange unified sewerage systems across 3 Uttarakhand towns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) on Wednesday said a sewerage network developed under the Namami Gange programme has brought the sewerage systems of Rishikesh, Tapovan and Muni Ki Reti under a single framework, transforming wastewater management in the region.

The NMCG emphasised that the transformation is not the result of a single project but of a comprehensive restructuring of the region's wastewater management system.

According to the mission, before the programme was launched, drains from Rishikesh flowed directly into the Ganga, sewage treatment capacity was limited, and the sewerage systems of Rishikesh,



Representational image

Tapovan and Muni Ki Reti operated independently.

The NMCG said the work began in 2017 to bring the three adjoining urban areas under a unified sewerage network as part of the Namami Gange programme. The mission further informed that with an investment of ₹375 crore, the network established a total sewage treatment capacity of 55 MLD.

The system comprises modern sewage treatment plants equipped with

automation and tertiary treatment facilities, while drains have been intercepted and diverted to prevent untreated sewage from entering the Ganga. According to the NMCG, six of the seven sanctioned projects have been completed, while one project is under construction.

The mission said the projects were approved in 2017, the construction of sewage treatment plants began in 2018, Tapovan was integrated into the network in 2019,

and Muni Ki Reti was connected in 2022.

The integrated system has strengthened Ganga conservation in the region by ensuring wastewater is treated before being discharged into the river, the NMCG said, adding that it has laid the foundation for cleaner stretches of the Ganga at Rishikesh, where the Himalayan river enters the plains.

"The result is visible in the Ganga. The water that once flowed untreated further downstream now reaches the river only after treatment. In the very city through which the Ganga passes as it descends from the Himalayas before entering the plains, the foundation of its cleanliness has already been laid," the NMCG said in a post on social media. "The city has changed. The Ganga has changed," it added.

Woman delivers quadruplets in auto; newborns die after ambulance delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A serious lapse in Madhya Pradesh's emergency health-care system came under scanner after a 28-year-old woman delivered four premature babies inside an auto-rickshaw in Mandla district when a 108 ambulance allegedly failed to reach her in time. All four newborns died, while the mother survived.

The incident occurred on Tuesday in Naiganwa village, where Rajni Sindram, who was around seven months pregnant, developed severe labour pain. Her family said they immediately called the 108 ambulance service, but the vehicle did not arrive despite repeated requests for help.

With Rajni's condition deteriorating rapidly, the family was left with no choice but to hire an auto-rickshaw and rush her to the Ghutas Primary Health Centre with the assistance of an ASHA worker. After providing initial treatment, doctors referred



her to the Bichhiya Community Health Centre for specialised care.

The referral, however, came too late. Before the auto-rickshaw could reach Bichhiya, Rajni delivered four babies one after another inside the vehicle. The accompanying ASHA worker assisted the delivery under extremely difficult circumstances and ensured that the mother reached the hospital safely.

Doctors at the Bichhiya Community Health Centre examined the newborns and

declared all four dead.

Bichhiya Block Medical Officer Anoop Kumar Bharatiya said Rajni was approximately 30 weeks pregnant and the babies were born prematurely.

He said the delivery had already taken place before the woman reached the hospital. The mother was given emergency treatment and her condition is now stable.

Rajni's husband, Dhanesh Sindram, blamed the delay in the Government ambulance service for the tragedy.

"My wife was six to seven months pregnant. We had to take her to hospital in an auto-rickshaw because no ambulance was available. She delivered on the way. All four babies died, but my wife survived," he said.

ASHA worker Manto Singram said she was informed that the family was bringing Rajni in an auto-rickshaw after labour pains started suddenly. She met them en route and helped manage the emergency delivery before they reached the hospital.

The incident has once again exposed glaring shortcomings in the state's emergency medical response system, raising uncomfortable questions about the reliability of the 108 ambulance network.

The deaths of four newborns before they could receive medical care have intensified demands for accountability and a thorough inquiry into whether timely emergency transport could have prevented the tragedy.

Amit Shah speaks to CMs of rain-hit States, assures help

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke with the chief ministers of Maharashtra, Gujarat, Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday to review the impact of heavy rains. He assured them that the Centre would provide all possible help, officials said.

Officials said the home minister called Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah. During these separate calls, Shah assured each chief minister that the Centre would offer all possible assistance to handle the rain-related situation, officials said.

Mumbai saw heavy rain on Wednesday, which delayed local trains and made commuting difficult for officegoers. The city had already faced heavy rain over the weekend, but experienced a short break on Tuesday. Long-distance trains to

Gujarat were still disrupted due to waterlogging on the Vasai-Virar section in Palghar district and at several places in south Gujarat.

Train services on the Mumbai-Pune route had not yet fully resumed after landslides hit the Bor Ghat section. Civic officials said Tulse Lake, one of Mumbai's seven drinking water reservoirs, began overflowing late at night because of heavy rain in its catchment area.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast light to moderate rain in Mumbai and its suburbs throughout the day.

Southern Gujarat also received "extremely heavy" rainfall on Tuesday, with the worst affected being Surat district, where five people died in rain-related incidents. In comparison, 2,100 people were shifted from flooded areas to safe locations, officials said.

Kamrej taluka in Surat district recorded 305 mm of rain in just 10 hours ending at 4 pm on Tuesday, officials said. Schools and colleges in the



Pedestrians make their way through a severely waterlogged road following heavy rainfall in Surat Gujarat on Wednesday

Navsari district and Surat remained closed on Tuesday due to heavy rain.

"Extremely heavy rainfall occurred at isolated places in the districts of South Gujarat region, namely Surat, Valsad, Dadra & Nagar Haveli in the last 24 hours," the IMD said in its midday state forecast on Tuesday.

M Nagarajan, Commissioner of Surat Municipal Corporation (SMC), told reporters that about 2,100 people had been moved from different zones to safe shelters. A district disaster management official said

five people had died in rain-related incidents over the past two days.

"Two deaths due to electrocution" Two deaths due to electrocution were reported today, while another person died in the Kamrej area. On Monday, two individuals died from electrocution in the Rander area of Surat," the official had said.

Heavy rainfall struck the upper reaches of Thathri town in Jammu and Kashmir's Doda district on Tuesday, partially damaging several houses, shops and

Uriamghat tax demand linked to identified miscreants, not Naga community: Pijush Hazarika

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Assam Government on Wednesday clarified that the recent incident involving an alleged demand for ₹110 from households in villages along the Uriamghat border area was the work of a few identified miscreants and should not be associated with the Naga community or the Government of Nagaland.

Replying to a Notice under Rule 54 raised by MLA Nurul Huda in the Assam Legislative Assembly, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Pijush Hazarika said a report from the Superintendent of Police (Border), Golaghat, revealed that two individuals from Hukai Basti in Nagaland's Nuland district visited Rajapukhuri villages under Uriamghat Police Station on June 23.

They allegedly distributed letters to village headmen directing them to collect ₹110 per household as House Tax and Census Tax in the name of NSCN/IMPRN (Nikki).

Hazarika urged people not to generalise the actions of a handful of anti-social elements or blame the entire Naga community, stressing that such assumptions could harm the long-standing cordial relations between the people of Assam and



Nagaland.

The Minister informed the House that the identities of the two accused have been established, but they remain absconding.

The matter has been communicated to the CRPF, neutral forces and the Border Magistrate at Sarupathar, while police and security agencies have intensified search operations, patrolling and surveillance in the border areas.

According to the latest police

report, no evidence has emerged to suggest that any money was actually collected from villagers.

Hazarika said the law and order situation in the area remains peaceful and is being closely monitored.

Reaffirming the State Government's commitment to the safety of border residents, the Minister said strict legal action would be taken against those responsible and that measures were being strengthened to prevent similar incidents in the future.

ED freezes TMC's ₹440 crore funds after West Bengal poll loss



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Kolkata/New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has frozen the Trinamool Congress (TMC)'s bank deposits worth ₹440.42 crore under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, dealing the party a severe financial setback at a critical juncture. The TMC, recently ousted from power in West Bengal by the BJP, now faces a paralysing restriction on its funds weeks after losing the state assembly elections.

The freeze hits the party when it is already reeling from internal rebellion and the challenges of operating as the principal opposition in the state. The ED has provisionally attached ₹440.42 crore lying in three private bank accounts of the All India Trinamool Congress under Section 17(1-A) of the PMLA.

This comes after Tuesday's raids at premises linked to Carewell Group and its aviation arm, Carewell Aviation. According to ED officials, the probe has uncovered transfers of around ₹160 crore from TMC accounts to Carewell Aviation and related entities between April 2023 and June 2026. These funds were allegedly used to purchase an Embraer Legacy 600 jet and an AugustaWestland 109SP helicopter for ₹112 crore, which were then rented back to the party.

The political implications of this freeze are profound and far-reaching for the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC. Having lost power in West Bengal for the first time in over a decade, the TMC is already in a weakened position. The freeze of

nearly ₹440 crore, a substantial part of its war chest, severely limits its ability to mount an effective opposition, fund protests, support party workers, or fight legal battles against the new BJP Government.

The ED order comes just days after the Calcutta High Court directed banks to disclose the corpus in these accounts. It follows last month's debit freeze by Kolkata Police, triggered by complaints from rebel TMC MLAs. The party is now battling on multiple fronts, while its finances are locked.

As an opposition party, the TMC will find it extremely difficult to sustain large-scale political programmes, cadre mobilisation, or election-related expenses in the coming months. This could accelerate demoralisation among workers and leaders at a time when unity is most needed.

Political observers say that the attachment of such a large amount under the stringent PMLA sends a strong signal about the central agency's reach into the finances of a major regional party that was in power until recently. It places the Mamata Banerjee-led faction under intense political and financial pressure.

There has been no immediate response from the Trinamool Congress or Carewell Aviation to the latest development. For the TMC, already navigating the difficult transition from ruling party to opposition, the ₹440 crore lock-in could prove a long-term handicap in its efforts to regroup and challenge the BJP in West Bengal.

Congress battles factions ahead of MP's Datia by-election

GIRISH SHARMA ■ Bhopal

With the July 30 by-election to Madhya Pradesh's Datia Assembly constituency fast approaching, the Congress finds itself balancing electoral strategy with internal party dynamics, even as both the Congress and the BJP are yet to announce their candidates.

The bypoll, necessitated by the disqualification of former Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti following his conviction in a decades-old bank fraud case, has emerged as a crucial political contest in the Gwalior-Chambal region.

While nominations close on July 13, the Congress leadership continues to deliberate over a candidate capable of retaining the seat without triggering factional unrest.

In a significant political development, Rajendra

Bharti has publicly conveyed to the party leadership that his family need not be considered for the ticket if the Congress identifies a stronger candidate. He said he would campaign wholeheartedly for any nominee chosen by the party and work to ensure the party's victory.

Speaking over the phone, Bharti said the final decision had been left entirely to the party high command. "It is not necessary that I or my family contest. If the party finds a better candidate, I will support that person with full commitment," he said.

His statement is widely being viewed as an attempt to project party loyalty at a time when the Congress is trying to avoid a repeat of the internal discord witnessed during the 2023 Assembly elections. In that election, the party had initially



declared former Textbook Corporation Vice-Chairman Avdhesh Nayak as its candidate before replacing him with Rajendra Bharti following strong opposition from Bharti's supporters.

With Bharti now stepping back from pressing his family's claim, two names have emerged prominently in Congress circles — Avdhesh Nayak and two-time former

MPA Ghanshyam Singh. Party leaders also indicate that a candidate from the Other Backward Classes could be considered if the leadership believes it would improve the party's electoral prospects.

Political observers believe Bharti's statement serves multiple purposes. It helps present him as a disciplined party leader willing to place organisational interests

above personal ambition, while also reducing the possibility of resistance from rival aspirants during the ticket selection process. At the same time, his political past adds another dimension to the calculations. Bharti has previously switched parties after being denied a ticket and has served as an MLA on a Samajwadi Party ticket, making the Congress leadership cautious about managing competing interests within the organisation.

The bypoll itself was triggered after Bharti lost his Assembly membership following his conviction in a bank fraud case dating back to 1998. The case relates to alleged manipulation of a fixed deposit at the Datia Cooperative Rural Development Bank, where investigators alleged that bank records were altered to

extend the tenure of an FD from three years to 15 years, enabling withdrawal of interest over several years. Bharti, who was then associated with the bank's management, was among those prosecuted.

On April 1, a special MP-MLA court in Delhi convicted Bharti in the 28-year-old case. A day later, the court sentenced him to three years' imprisonment and imposed a fine of Rs 1 lakh. Although the court granted him time to appeal, the conviction remained in force.

For the Congress, the election is more than a routine bypoll. It is a test of its ability to manage factional equations while retaining a constituency it won in 2023. Candidate selection will be critical, as the party seeks to avoid alienating influential local leaders and maintain organisational unity.

Police shoot dead Baruiপুর gang-rape accused in encounter

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Suvendu Adhikari Government tended to walk its talk — against sexual attacks on women — dealing out on Wednesday the 'encounter treatment' for Probbash Mondal the prime accused in Baruiপুর gangrape and murder case even as he "tried to snatch a gun from the policemen, open fire and flee" before being shot dead.

"As he was continuously changing his statements the police team was taking him to the place of occurrence for reconstruction of the crime situation, when he suddenly snatched a gun from a policeman and opened fire... the accompanying policemen immediately fired back in self-defence hitting him in the chest and abdomen," a senior



Security personnel stand guard outside Baruiপুর Sub-Divisional Hospital, where the body of an accused killed in a police encounter has been kept, in South 24 Parganas district, West Bengal, Wednesday

police officer said.

While Wednesday's was the first death in police firing after many years, perhaps after the naxalite movement of the seventies residents of Baruiপুর and the family members of the victim received the news contently.

"We have complete faith in Chief Minister Suvendu Babu

...he told us the other day that he will not spare the guilty and give a lesson that would be remembered by the future criminals, we are satisfied that at least one of them has been treated befittingly, as instead of repenting he was shamelessly attacking the police men," the brother of the victim said.

A 12-year-old girl was

waylaid last Saturday by a gang of 5-6 youths at Baruiপুর, a suburban town south of Kolkata. She was then gangraped and brutally assaulted with several hits on her head. To ensure death, she was stuffed in a gunny bag and thrown into a pond so that she died from drowning. Her post-mortem reports confirmed lethal ante mortem injuries and death by drowning.

The incident triggered widespread outrage, with angry locals blocking the Baruiপুর-Joynagar Road, setting tyres ablaze and vandalising police vehicles, demanding immediate arrest and stringent punishment for those responsible.

Incidentally Adhikari as an Opposition Leader during one of his campaigns said that the BJP Government

would teach the ultimate lesson to all the rapists adding "we 'deposit' them in the morning and 'spend' them in the evening before producing them in the court."

Meanwhile, senior Congress leader Adhir Chowdhury and TMC leader Mohua Moitra attacked the powers that be in the State for converting Bengal "officially into UP 2.0."

"Isn't it strange that the prime accused and the only witness in the rape and murder case has been shot dead in an alleged encounter... with him many information may have gone forever... it is a blood thirsty day... for the first time in Bengal we have seen an encounter killing. Bengal has officially become UP 2.0" she said wondering why the police could not aim at the feet which was the standard rule.



A joint delegation comprising representatives from the Bodo Sahitya Sabha, United Bodo People's Organisation and Bodo Kachari Welfare Autonomous Council called upon CM Himanta Biswa Sarma

PIONEER PHOTO

Editor's

TAKE

Delhi's ridge gets a second chance

Delhi has launched its most ambitious afforestation drive in years but it will mean little unless it is matched by cutting emissions at their source

Delhi's ridge – the northern extension of the Aravalli hills that runs through the capital – has long been called the city's "green lungs." This week, that metaphor was given fresh political weight when Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta planted saplings at the Central Ridge and Nanakpura Ridge to launch a campaign to plant 70 lakh trees across the capital, part of a broader push under the "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" initiative. The government has also launched a Green Drive Portal letting citizens book plantation slots, request free saplings and register as "Environmental Saviours," with a focus on native, long-living species such as peepal, banyan, neem, arjun and jamun, alongside plans for 100 Oxygen Parks across the city. Crucially, Shah pointed out that 7,784 hectares of the Ridge were notified under the Indian Forest Act back in 1994, but the final notification has never been issued in the three decades since – leaving much of this land legally unprotected and vulnerable to encroachment.

Now, 5,000 hectares have been designated forest area, with a promise to extend legal protection to the entire Ridge. That promise, if kept, matters more than the sapling count. It matters because Delhi's pollution crisis is not seasonal bad luck – it is structural. Vehicular emissions contribute the largest share of the city's local PM2.5 pollution, at over half the total, while neighbouring districts add roughly a third more through dust and industrial emissions carried in from outside Delhi's borders. Winter brings crop-residue burning from neighbouring states, whose smoke gets trapped near the ground by temperature inversions and calm winds, producing weeks-long smog episodes. In 2025, Delhi's annual average PM2.5 concentration touched 99.6 micrograms per cubic metre, making it the fourth most polluted city in the world – a level nearly twenty times the WHO's safety guideline. Summers bring their own hazard, as dust storms and heatwave conditions push AQI readings past 400. This is a year-round, multi-source emergency. Given that, a plantation drive – however large – addresses only one layer of the problem. Trees absorb some particulate matter, stabilise soil, cool micro-climates and, over decades, rebuild an ecosystem that construction and encroachment have steadily eaten into. Delhi residents online have already voiced the obvious worry: past plantation drives have seen saplings die for lack of watering and follow-up care, and choosing hardy but low-value species like babool over biodiversity-rich natives has sometimes done more for optics than ecology.

A three-tier, native-species approach with dedicated maintenance – as this programme promises – is a meaningfully better design, if it is followed through. But real, sustained relief requires enforcing vehicular emission standards, cleaning up industrial discharge, cutting fossil-fuel power generation, and forging real coordination with neighbouring states on crop burning. The 300 electric buses flagged off alongside the plantation drive are a start on the transport front. The Ridge deserves its legal protection and its trees. Delhi's lungs need much more than that.



MANJARI SINGH

Two developments this week show how readily the great powers and multilateral institutions will settle the fate of another conflict in the Middle East. At Lake Lucerne, the United States and Iran agreed a roadmap to wind down the war in Lebanon and built a mechanism to govern the fighting between Israel and Hezbollah, while Israel itself was given no seat at the table. In Geneva, the UN Human Rights Council received a report accusing Israel of the gravest crimes in international law over its conduct towards the children of Gaza. India holds no stake in either battlefield, yet has reason to watch how this second judgment was reached.

The death of a child is the heaviest sorrow a society can carry, and that it is no lighter for the nationality the child happened to hold. A child killed in Gaza is an irreplaceable world ended; so is a child in Tel Aviv, or on a road in the Kashmir Valley. To ask how a child died, and at whose hand, is the seriousness that might protect the next one.

There is another moral question that deserves reflection in India. The massacres of October 7, in which Israeli civilians, including children, were murdered, kidnapped and brutalised, marked the beginning of this war. Yet many voices that now speak with certainty about Israel's conduct had little or nothing to say when those atrocities occurred. Moral concern cannot be selective. A standard that condemns civilian suffering only after one side responds, while remaining silent when the violence that triggered the conflict is unleashed, diminishes its own credibility. One may criticise Israel's actions and still recognise that any serious moral accounting of this war must begin with October 7. To omit that starting point is not impartiality; it is incompleteness.

In 2018 and again in 2019, the Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights issued reports on Jammu and Kashmir that New Delhi rejected as fallacious, tendentious and motivated. The objection was never that Kashmiri suffering was unreal; no honest Indian would say so. The objection was to the UN system. A UN office had assembled unverified figures, relied on interested testimony, set aside the long history of cross-border terrorism, and pronounced a confident verdict on a place it had no standing to judge. Governments in Delhi of every stripe have

The weaponisation of the UN

As the war in Gaza continues to divide global opinion, a new United Nations report accusing Israel of grave violations against Palestinian children has reignited questions not only about accountability, but also about the credibility and consistency of international institutions



more than a million children vaccinated against polio in coordination with the WHO, and the diversion of humanitarian aid by the armed groups themselves. One need not settle any of these to see the difficulty: Each judgment falls the same way, against the accused, and a tribunal whose every doubt resolves in one direction is not weighing evidence. It is ratifying a verdict it brought with it.

There is also a distinction that should matter to a democracy. A democracy carries the means of its own correction: courts that rule against the government, a free press, an electorate that removes it. Israel, whatever one concludes about its conduct, has these institutions; the armed movements arrayed against it offer their people none.

Candour is owed about the forum doing the judging. The human-rights machinery of the United Nations carries a long and uneven record, having seated serial abusers on its councils and trained a permanent focus on one democracy while openly repressive states drew little notice. Such a body has not earned the authority to pronounce final verdicts on a sovereign nation, and the principle does not bend according to which nation stands in the dock. Accountability imposed from outside, on evidence a state was never allowed to test, only imitates the rule of law.

This is the pattern India must recognise, because it was once turned against India itself. A standing body, insulated from accountability, selects a single sovereign state, assembles a record it does not let that state test, and converts a political campaign into the language of law and its gravest charges. The instrument is the human-rights report; the purpose is the weaponisation of the United Nations against an unfavourable state.

Verdicts handed down from Geneva harden the warring and embolden those who profit from grievance; they have never stopped a war or returned a child to a parent. Peace is made by states willing to talk, and made faster when the world resists anointing permanent villains and victims. India's instinct, shaped by its own experience, has favoured dialogue over denunciation. The children of Gaza and of Tel Aviv need a peace two peoples can be helped to build. That is the cause India should keep in view.

held that line since.

That is the lens through which the Gaza report deserves to be read. This Commission is the only standing body in the UN system aimed permanently at a single country, created by a resolution that half the Council declined to support. It rests its conclusions on testimony it cannot independently verify and, in places, on its own previous reports; it reaches determinations on ballistics and military operations for which it has no evident expertise, then dresses them as legal findings, though it is no court and can convict no one. It allowed the accused state ten days to answer a hundred-page document covering three years of war. None of this certifies Israel's account of any single incident. But the report's central claims are precisely the kind an impartial process would treat as contested rather than settled.

Much turns on disputed ground. The Commission's own reports have not kept their ratios of children to combatants consistent. Its treatment of schools and hospitals sets aside a documented pattern of armed groups operating from within civilian sites, the fact that decides whether a strike was a crime or a tragedy of war: weapons recovered from a kindergarten, a tunnel shaft beneath an infant's cot, an attack on the Al-Taba'een site that the report lists without recording that the building had become a base for militants. The account of the Al-Ahli hospital explosion, attributed to Israel within hours, was later contradicted by American, British and Canadian assessments pointing to a misfired Palestinian rocket.

On starvation, the report passes over the

A UN OFFICE HAD ASSEMBLED UNVERIFIED FIGURES, RELIED ON INTERESTED TESTIMONY, SET ASIDE THE LONG HISTORY OF CROSS-BORDER TERRORISM, AND PRONOUNCED A CONFIDENT VERDICT ON A PLACE IT HAD NO STANDING TO JUDGE. GOVERNMENTS IN DELHI OF EVERY STRIPE HAVE HELD THAT LINE SINCE.

Dr Manjari Singh is a strategic affairs expert specialising in the Middle East and Greater West Asia

Elder care is not optional, it is a social responsibility



GEETANJALI CHOPRA

2ND OPINION

In India, there was a time when caring for the elderly was not discussed as an option—it was simply a way of life. Respect and regard for ageing parents were not choices, but deeply internalised social norms woven into everyday living. Today, that understanding is steadily weakening. Elder care is increasingly being treated as a matter of choice, shaped by convenience rather than commitment. This shift reflects not just a cultural change, but a deeper gap in how India is preparing for an ageing society.

India is home to nearly 144 million senior citizens, and this number is expected to rise sharply in the coming decades. Yet despite these numbers, programmes focused on improving their living conditions remain strikingly few. As a result, ageing is rarely accompanied by dignity; instead, it is often marked by neglect and invisibility. Equally con-

cerning is the growing proportion of elderly living alone or only with a spouse. These people are more vulnerable to fraud, theft and even violent crime due to limited mobility and predictable routines.

Beyond these visible risks lies a quieter crisis—elders battling illness without support, spending days without meaningful interaction, and in some cases, passing away unnoticed. These are not isolated incidents, but symptoms of a systemic apathy towards elder care. The reasons behind this shift are well known. Migration, expensive urban housing, demanding work lives and changing priorities have reshaped family structures. At the same time, many elderly individuals choose to remain in familiar surroundings, rooted in their communities. What has emerged is a widening gap between generations—not just physically, but emotionally. India is moving away from informal, family-led elder care, but has not built adequate formal systems to replace it. As a result, a growing number of seniors are left to navigate ageing largely on their own. India has legal provisions such as the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, which obligate children to provide for their parents' basic needs. Additionally, the National Policy on Older Persons and schemes under the Integrated Programme for Senior Citizens aim to provide financial security, healthcare access and shelter. While important, such frameworks address only one part of the problem. Care cannot be reduced to obligation alone. It is not just about financial support, but about presence, attention and dignity. Law can enforce duty, but it cannot create

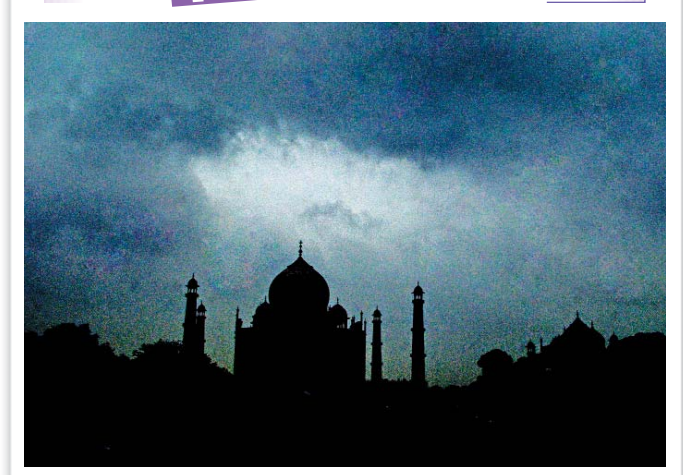
care or emotional security. Many elderly individuals remain unaware of their legal rights, limiting their ability to seek support. At the community level, Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) can play a far more structured role by maintaining registries of elderly residents living alone, enabling periodic welfare checks, and creating emergency response systems. Such decentralised mechanisms can significantly reduce both isolation and risk. Similarly, the role of local police must move beyond symbolic outreach. Old-age homes are an important part of the solution.

They provide shelter, healthcare and companionship. However, their limited reach and affordability prevent them from becoming a universal solution. There is also significant scope for corporate engagement. Elder care can be meaningfully integrated into Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), particularly through partnerships with credible non-governmental organisations to build community-based care models. In earlier days elder care was part of a social fabric that ensured continuity between generations.

Rebuilding this fabric requires more than policy—it demands a conscious effort to restore intergenerational bonds. Families, schools and communities must create spaces where younger generations remain connected to their elders. If ageing is to become one of India's defining realities, elder care must move from being seen as a private concern to a shared social responsibility.

The writer works for the elderly care and founder of Wishes and Blessings NGO

PIC TALK



Monsoon clouds hover over the Taj Mahal amid rainy weather, in Agra

PHOTO: PTI

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DOWRY DEATHS DEMAND STRONGER SOCIAL AND LEGAL ACTION

The tragic death of 28-year-old Akriti, barely 72 days after her marriage, is yet another grim reminder that the evil of dowry continues to claim innocent lives despite stringent laws. According to her family's complaint, the man she loved and married allegedly became abusive soon after the wedding, demanding dowry, seeking control over her salary, forcing her to quit her job, and subjecting her to relentless physical and mental harassment. Her repeated warnings that her husband might kill her make this case particularly shocking and heartbreaking.

Such incidents expose not only the failure of legal deterrence but also the persistence of regressive social attitudes that treat women as commodities rather than equal partners. While every person involved in such harassment must be brought to justice, the husband

bears the primary responsibility for either protecting or persecuting his wife. The law must ensure swift investigation, speedy trials, and exemplary punishment for those guilty of dowry-related crimes.

At the same time, families, educational institutions, women's organisations, and civil society must work together to eradicate this social evil and create an environment where every woman can live with dignity, safety, and respect after marriage.

The fight against dowry demands uncompromising enforcement of the law, greater social awareness, and a collective rejection of practices that commodify women. Only when society treats daughters with dignity and refuses to tolerate dowry will such tragic deaths finally come to an end.

RS NARULA PATIALA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India must closely watch developments in PoK

Pakistan's violent crackdown on protesters in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) reflects its growing unease over the rising public demand for basic rights and political freedom. The increasing demonstrations reveal deep public resentment against prolonged political neglect, economic hardship, and denial of democratic rights.

Faced with mounting internal and external pressure, Islamabad appears to be suppressing dissent in PoK instead of addressing the legitimate grievances of its people. Such heavy-handed measures are only likely to intensify public anger and further destabilise the region. India should closely monitor developments in PoK and continue highlighting the human rights situation through diplomatic and international forums. While respecting international norms,

New Delhi should extend moral and humanitarian support to the people who are seeking justice, dignity, and fundamental freedoms.

The international community must also take note of these developments and urge Pakistan to uphold democratic values, respect human rights, and refrain from using force to silence peaceful voices.

DR DVG SANKARA RAO | VISHAKHAPATNAM

Bharat Taxi must build passenger trust

Bharat Taxi has the potential to emerge as a credible, people-centric alternative to app-based cab aggregators, but its long-term success will depend on much more than offering affordable fares. As highlighted in the report, the cooperative model can succeed only if it consistently delivers a safe, reliable, and respectful travel experience.

If drivers engage in the same practices that have frustrated passengers on other platforms—such as refusing rides, demanding extra money, or behaving discourteously—the initiative will quickly lose public confidence. Therefore, accountability must be built into the system from the outset. Transparent, surge-free pricing, digital receipts, and an efficient grievance redressal mechanism should be made mandatory. Since Bharat Taxi drivers are co-owners of the cooperative, repeated misconduct should invite strict disciplinary action, including suspension of membership and loss of cooperative benefits. More importantly, drivers must recognise that every instance of misconduct damages the reputation of the cooperative. Bharat Taxi can become a truly dependable mobility solution only by upholding passenger trust through discipline & professionalism.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Social media challenges need urgent action

Social media has become an influential platform for communication and entertainment, but it is also increasingly being misused to spread misinformation and promote dangerous online trends. In recent years, viral challenges have encouraged reckless behaviour, putting countless young lives at risk. Earlier, the infamous 'Blue Whale' challenge was linked to several tragic deaths worldwide. Now, equally hazardous trends such as the 'Momo' challenge and the 'Kiki' challenge have exposed users, particularly teenagers, to unnecessary risks.

The Kiki challenge, which dares participants to step out of a moving vehicle, dance alongside it, and jump back in while being filmed, has resulted in numerous accidents and injuries across countries. The pursuit of online fame through likes, comments, and shares often overshadows concerns for personal safety. Parents, schools, social media companies, and law enforcement agencies must work together to educate young users about the dangers of such trends. Technology platforms should promptly remove harmful content and discourage challenges that threaten public safety. Responsible digital behaviour and stronger content moderation are essential to ensure that social media remains a tool for creativity and communication rather than a source of preventable tragedies.

JAYANTHY SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

Beyond E20: Making India’s ethanol transition truly sustainable

As blending targets rise, the focus must shift beyond percentages alone. The long-term success of India’s ethanol strategy will depend on balancing energy independence with water security, agricultural sustainability, environmental safeguards, vehicle compatibility, and food security



DEBAJIT PALIT | AKANKSHA JAIN

India’s ethanol-blending programme has evolved rapidly over the last decade from a limited effort to blend with petrol to now one of the central pillars for India’s energy security and clean mobility strategy. The country has already achieved E20 blending ahead of schedule, increasing it gradually from 1.5% in 2014. The central government is now preparing for higher blends through the recent notification and recent launch of flex-fuel vehicles (FFVs).

The rationale for ethanol blending has been to reduce fossil oil imports and thus provide a degree of insulation from global oil price volatility, supply shocks and geopolitical disruptions. According to government reports, this transformation has helped save over ₹1.84 lakh crore in foreign exchange over the years and substituted more than 300 lakh metric tonnes of oil imports. Ethanol blending has thus been positioned as a strategic tool to reduce fossil oil consumption, lower foreign exchange outflows, build domestic fuel resilience and at the same time create additional income for farmers. However, the blending has also been questioned by critiques citing many challenges and thus they need to be addressed for better acceptance of the programme.

On the consumer side, an often-cited challenge is the issue of fuel efficiency and impact of fuel blends on the engine. As ethanol has ~30% lower energy density than petrol, ethanol blends reduce vehicle mileage, particularly for vehicles that are non-E20 compliant. Furthermore, the hygroscopic property of ethanol can lead to moisture accumulation, corrosion of fuel system components, and potential breakdowns of non-compliant vehicles. In this scenario, the recent FFV notification is an important policy step. By introducing engine compliance standards, the government has recognised that higher blending requires compatible vehicle systems.

On the supply side, India’s ethanol ecosystem today remains dominated by first-generation (1G) feedstocks, particularly sugarcane, maize and broken rice. This has generated important gains for the farmers, as sugar mill arrears, historically a major source of farmer distress, have reduced significantly. Because of the rising demand from the distilleries, maize cultivation has expanded. For policymakers, ethanol has become an instrument that simultaneously addresses energy security, rural income generation, and agricultural market stability.

While a higher blend beyond E20 for the FFV has the potential to further reduce our fossil oil consumption and thus foreign exchange outflows, the next phase of India’s ethanol programme must be evaluated through a broader ‘systems’ perspective that considers not only energy security but also ecological sustainability and long-term resource resilience. Sugarcane is among the most water-intensive crops cultivated in India and is often grown in regions already experiencing groundwater stress. Its cultivation is supported by significant electricity subsidies for irrigation and high fertiliser inputs.

Maize is also increasingly entering the fuel economy as ethanol demand rises. As more maize is diverted towards ethanol production, domestic availability for poultry feed, starch and other industrial uses becomes tighter, increasing pressure on food-feed-fuel allocation and, in some years, contributing to higher imports. The larger concern here is whether India’s ethanol transition is substituting crude oil import dependence with growing dependence on subsidised groundwater, electricity for irrigation, imported fertilisers and, potentially, feed grain.

Furthermore, while ethanol may reduce tailpipe emissions, a rigorous comparative life cycle assessment (LCA) is essential to account for the full production chain, including fertiliser manufacture and use, groundwater extraction, electricity consumption for



WHILE INDIA’S ETHANOL PROGRAMME HAS UNDOUBTEDLY SUPPORTED RURAL INCOMES, ITS NEXT PHASE SHOULD BE GUIDED BY A ‘SYSTEMS’ PERSPECTIVE RATHER THAN BLENDING TARGETS ALONE. ENERGY SECURITY CANNOT BE SEPARATED FROM GROUNDWATER STRESS, FERTILISER DEPENDENCE, AGRICULTURAL RESILIENCE, WASTE MANAGEMENT, AND LONG-TERM RESOURCE SUSTAINABILITY AND SECURITY

Dr. Akanksha Jain is a Research Associate and Dr. Debjit Palit is the Centre Head at the Centre for Climate Change and Energy Transition at Chintan Research Foundation

irrigation, transportation, distillation energy, land-use changes associated with feedstock cultivation, waste generation and treatment, and emissions across the value chain. Only such a cradle-to-grave assessment can determine whether higher ethanol blends deliver genuine net environmental gains under Indian conditions.

The environmental assessment must also extend beyond feedstock cultivation to include waste management. Distilleries reportedly generate large volumes of effluent with significant pollution potential, if inadequately treated. Although regulatory norms mandate treatment and reuse through bio-methanation, concentration or composting, a rapid expansion of ethanol production will proportionately increase waste volumes.

A major concern is also on the long-term impact on agricultural patterns. If ethanol demand continues to incentivise sugarcane and maize cultivation, what happens to crop diversification and soil resilience? Monoculture expansion may improve short-term farmer incomes, but over time weaken ecological stability and increase resource stress, thereby impacting the farmers themselves. There is also an implicit food security dimension. The current policy support still disproportionately favours rapid expansion of 1G infrastructure because it is easier to scale quickly. That may help India achieve blending targets and reduce foreign exchange outflow, but it risks locking into a resource-intensive biofuel pathway with longer term impacts on soil and groundwater. While surplus and waste 1G feedstocks should be used to produce ethanol, any expansion through additional cultivation must be preceded by a comprehensive and rigorous life cycle assessment (LCA).

This is precisely why India must work on prioritising second-generation (2G) biofuels. India generates up to 500 million tonnes of agricultural residues annually, much of which is burned, contributing to severe air pollution. Converting crop residues, municipal waste, and non-food biomass into ethanol offers a far more sustainable pathway than indefinite expansion of first-generation feedstocks. However, 2G ethanol remains commercially challenging due to high capital costs of pre-treatment and lower yields. Going forward, the policy should simultaneously focus on enabling 2G systems through targeted financial incentives, innovation support, technology partnerships, and long-term procurement certainty. The objective should not merely be increasing ethanol percentages but creating a genuinely sustainable low-carbon fuel ecosystem.

While India’s ethanol programme has undoubtedly supported rural incomes, its next phase should be guided by a ‘systems’ perspective rather than blending targets alone. Energy security cannot be separated from groundwater stress, fertiliser dependence, agricultural resilience, waste management, and long-term resource sustainability and security. International experience, particularly Brazil’s, offers valuable lessons but should be interpreted in context. Much of Brazil’s sugarcane cultivation is rain-fed and takes place under agro-climatic conditions that differ from India’s, where irrigation and groundwater extraction play a larger role. Also, Brazil vehicle ecosystem for using blended fuels was simultaneously developed. India’s biofuel strategy must be tailored to its own resource constraints and conditions. Ultimately, the next phase of India’s ethanol transition should be evaluated not only as an energy security initiative, but also as a resource security strategy without impacting the vehicle users.

Litmus test awaits Jan-Suraaj in Bankipur



GYAN BHADRA

Even before the Election Commission of India issues a formal notification for the by-election to Bankipur assembly seat, the political temperature in Bihar and Patna in particular has already risen sharply. Political parties have begun a war of words to grab public attention, months ahead of the actual contest.

The seat fell vacant after the BJP’s central leadership elevated Nitin Nabin-winner of five consecutive elections, including once from the erstwhile Patna West constituency before delimitation to the post of national president. His new responsibilities require him to move to the Rajya Sabha, and he has accordingly resigned from the Bankipur assembly seat, triggering the by-election. The Election Commission is yet to announce the schedule, but parties across the spectrum are already positioning themselves for what promises to be a keenly fought contest. Bankipur is set to be one of the most closely watched contests in Bihar, for two broad reasons.

The first is the possibility that Prashant Kishor himself may contest. His candidature is yet to be formally cleared by Jan Suraaj’s working committee, but the mere prospect has already drawn heavy media attention. If Kishor does enter the fray, a significant section of voters who did not back the Jan Suraaj candidate in the 2025 assembly election could shift towards him this time. His appeal has largely been to professionals, government employees, the middle class and students—precisely the kind of urban, educated electorate that dominates Bankipur, and one likely to respond to his reformist, development-focused pitch.

The real question, however, is whether Jan Suraaj can convert this goodwill into actual votes—a difficult task given the party’s acknowledged weakness in booth-level organisation, an area where the BJP’s decades of grassroots presence give it a considerable head start. Jan Suraaj’s state president Manoj Bharti concedes as much: “Due to lack of skilled manpower, this has been our biggest mistake in the past. But this time around, we have rectified the mistake, strengthened the organisational power and honed up the necessary skills of booth management that could match up with those of BJP.”

The second reason is Bankipur’s status as a BJP bastion since 1990. The father-son duo of Navin Kumar Sinha and Nitin Nabin held the seat continuously from 1995 to 2025. Navin Kumar Sinha won from Patna West in 1995 and again in 2005, serving until his death in 2006. His son Nitin Nabin then won the ensuing by-election and went on to win four more consecutive terms through 2025. After the 2008 delimitation exercise, Patna West was renamed Bankipur.

The father-son duo, both Kayasthas by caste, benefited enormously from the constituency’s social composition, which is dominated by upper castes—Kayasthas alone account for roughly 23 percent of the electorate. This allowed them to build a durable personal support base over three decades. Beyond Kayasthas, the BJP has also drawn steady support from other upper-caste communities—Brahmins, Bhumihars, Rajputs, Vaishyas and Banias—making the seat nearly unassailable.

Manoj Bharti disputes this narrative of invincibility, arguing that voters are tired of the father-son duo and are actively seeking change, accusing them of doing too little for the constituency. He argues that Bankipur’s problem has not been loyalty to the BJP but apathy born of a lack of alternatives. “The people of Bankipur often used to say: what difference will it make whether I cast my vote or not? Nitin Nabin is going to win anyway,” Bharti says, adding that this time voters are showing greater willingness to turn out because they now see a genuine alternative. Bharti backs this with turnout figures: Bankipur has historically recorded voting percentages of just 34 to 39 percent, compared to 52 to 55 percent elsewhere in Bihar—evidence, he argues, of chronic voter disengagement rather than satisfaction with the incumbent. He also criticised the BJP-led state and central governments for failing to invite NITI Aayog members to Bihar to address the state’s economic troubles.

The BJP, for its part, has already begun groundwork. According to Prabhat Malakar, the party’s state media-in-charge, national president Nitin Nabin has held discussions with the president, vice-president and general secretary of each of the committees overseeing Bankipur’s ten electoral wards, to assess ground realities. This was followed by a closed-door meeting involving Nabin, state president and chief minister Samrat Chaudhary at the CM’s official residence. Malakar notes that since key election decisions are made in Delhi, the national president, chief minister and state president will jointly decide on the candidate once the Election Commission’s notification is issued, after which the party’s election committee will make its choice. On the likely candidate, Malakar indicated that the BJP is expected to field a Kayastha, given the constituency’s demographic profile, with names such as Ajay Alok, Sanjay Mayukh and Rituraj Sinha doing the rounds.

He expressed confidence that no rival party poses a real threat, citing the welfare schemes implemented by the father-son duo over the years, including new roads. He specifically highlighted Nitin Nabin’s role in transforming the Mandiri Nala into a covered box drain topped by a two-lane smart road—a project that eliminated foul odour, reduced flood risk in central Patna, and eased traffic congestion.

Malakar also pointed to a broader electoral pattern: the party that wins an assembly seat in a general election typically retains it in a subsequent by-election. Even so, should Prashant Kishor enter the race, retaining Nitin Nabin’s 2025 vote share of 62 percent would be no easy task for the BJP’s candidate, even in victory. Any noticeable dip in that margin would be read as a referendum on the state government’s popularity and the party’s organisational strength—making Bankipur’s outcome a matter of political prestige as much as electoral arithmetic. Unsurprisingly, the BJP is expected to spare no effort in ensuring its candidate wins by a commanding margin.



The author is a columnist

US-Iran peace talks fail: Lasting peace in West Asia remains as elusive as ever



JITENDRA KOJHA

The United States retaliation with overwhelming force, hitting more than 80 Iranian military targets underscored the poor trust, broken commitments, competing threat perceptions and strategic irreconcilability of the stakeholders that has defined the peace process right from the beginning. President Trump declared at the NATO summit in Ankara that the ceasefire had “finished”. He described the MoU as “a waste of time,” and labelled Iranian leaders as “liars” and “sick people.” Meanwhile, oil prices surged over 5% convulsing the global markets.

Iran has defended the attacks as assertion of sovereignty in quest for a “new Iranian order” in Hormuz. Despite enduring serious losses in leadership, infrastructure, and civilian lives, Tehran appears emboldened and the theocratic regime has entrenched itself further. This was manifest in global diplomatic acknowledgment in form of large-scale representation from major powers. Iran

clearly appears to be exploiting limits of conventional US-Israel military power to conclude the war in a complex geopolitical theatre, where Iran has so far appeared to enjoy advantages in asymmetric warfare.

It is intriguing that a regime that appeared poised to end its half a century long global isolation with removal of all sanctions and offer of a major economic reconstruction programme is seeking squander this opportunity. While an accidental re-ignition of conflict was always expected in the prevailing ambience of distrust, such deliberate confrontation indicates deeper underlying causes. Despite progress on formation of technical working groups on sanctions relief for Iran, agreement on nuclear issues through a closer inspection, and mechanisms to secure maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, as well as de-escalation of tensions in Lebanon, deeper security, ideological and geopolitical faultlines that fueled the war had remained unresolved. It is clear failure of stakeholders to stretch their capacity, commitment and innovation to translate the “agreement on a 60-day roadmap toward a final settlement” into an enduring peace and stability in the region.

American firepower with its formidable surveillance and precision strike capacity, stealth technology, logistics network and overall force projection, backed by Israel’s high tech-intelligence prowess has so far failed to vanquish Iran. Iran has largely held its ground, despite losing almost its entire top political-military leadership, thousands of trained IRGC personnel, almost half of its



air, naval and ground military assets, besides suffering tens of thousands of civilian casualties. Massive infrastructure damage, assessed in hundreds of billions of dollars, and big hits on key economic installations and ports also failed to dent Iran’s spirit. Low-cost high-impact Iranian drones, manufactured and deployed in very large numbers with flexibility, compelled US-Israeli forces to expend interceptor missiles costing 50 to 500 times more.

While direct U.S. military losses are estimated only around \$50 billion, with cumulative losses assessed at \$100 billion, the overall threat to American credibility and goodwill in the region and beyond appears profound. Energy production disruptions and infrastructure damage is assessed to have caused estimated GDP contraction to the tune of 3-6 percent for American allies in the gulf. Yet it appears that Iran’s success in low cost war, terms of MoU in Switzerland and global response

to Khamenei’s funeral has emboldened Iran to indulge in an audacity that has tested the patience of Trump.

Why Sustainable Peace Shall Be Difficult

Iranians had always suspected that Trump may use diplomacy as a smokescreen to topple the Iranian regime. Such apprehension is grounded in experiences of the past. US had initiated this war in February, just a day after Omani Foreign Minister had declared that an understanding had been reached between the two sides on all key issues. It appeared that Americans were preparing for the war using diplomacy as a distraction. Even in the current US retaliation, there appears detailed planning. Simultaneously, President Trump’s frequent recourse to high-risk deception, bluff, bullying and unpredictability may be effective bargaining strategy in tactical corporate deals. But these have dented his credibility as a responsible statesman. Iranians cannot be faulted from apprehending a possible reneging of Trump from terms of MoU signed at Switzerland. Simultaneously, Netanyahu has been the most potent threat to US-Iran peace. His intermittent attacks even after signing of MoU only corroborate this. The very character of Iranian regime poses an existential threat to Israel. But Netanyahu needs to keep the pot boiling in Iran to deflect his potential indictment in corruption charges. He may attempt a more audacious strike on Iran further doom the fate of peace in the region. Further, a degree of indirect Chinese support to

Iranian regime is assessed to have bolstered the latter’s capacities to challenge the combined US-Israeli might. China has appeared clear about its strategic objective to expel US and NATO from whole of Asia. Its proximity with Iran, and even others in West Asia, complicates the search for an endurable peace.

Simultaneously, Iran’s adversaries remain sceptical of Tehran’s long-term intentions. Iranian attacks on strait of Hormuz is likely to further deepen this distrust making the peace more elusive. Many Iranian regime insiders have continued to openly state that a nuclear weapon alone offered a credible deterrence against future aggressions. These are only going to exacerbate anxieties for other gulf states in the region. India and the Emerging Strategic Landscape As one of the world’s largest energy importers, India remains vulnerable to disruptions and instability in the Gulf, which impact energy prices, economic growth and inflation at home. It has not been able to leverage its wider acceptability across internal divides in the region. As a large nation with serious constraints, India needs stronger strategic capabilities, greater institutional agility and a deeply calibrated approach to influence and shape its external surroundings to a certain level. This is an existential necessity in an increasingly interconnected world where geopolitical conflicts and tensions deeply impact development and security far beyond theatres of conflict.

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Tribunal awards compensation to kin of road mishap victim



The Motor Accident Claims Tribunal in Thane has awarded a compensation of ₹31.43 lakh to the family of a man killed in a road accident, while holding him 15 per cent contributorily negligent for staying too close to the vehicle ahead.

In its order on Tuesday, the MACT directed the owner of a tempo involved in the accident and its insurer to jointly and severally pay the amount to the family of victim Rajaram Narayan Mhatre with 9 per cent interest per annum from the date of the petition.

According to the order, Mhatre was driving his Innova behind an Eicher tempo on the Pune-Nashik road on December 25, 2020, when the tempo driver suddenly applied brakes without any signal or indication. Mhatre's car crashed into the tempo, resulting in his death.

While the insurance company argued that Mhatre was solely responsible for the crash as he rammed the vehicle from behind, the Tribunal Member RV Mohite noted that both drivers shared responsibility.

The tribunal also noted that Mhatre did not maintain a "safe distance" between the tempo and his Innova car. Assessing the negligence of the tempo driver at 85 per cent and Mhatre at 15 per cent, the tribunal initially computed the total compensation at ₹36.98 lakh.

After taking into account Mhatre's contributory negligence, it directed the opponents to pay ₹31.43 lakh. (PTI)

Quota benefits: TN moves SC against Madras HC verdict

The Tamil Nadu Government has approached the Supreme Court, challenging a Madras High Court judgment that held a person converting to Islam is not entitled to claim reservation under the Backward Class (Muslim) category solely on the basis of conversion. The appeal has been filed by the secretary to the state Government against the high court's decision, which declared unconstitutional a Government Order (GO) issued on March 9, 2024.

The impugned GO had permitted persons belonging to Backward Classes (BC), Most Backward Classes (MBC), Denotified Communities (DNC), or Scheduled Castes (SC) who subsequently converted to Islam to be treated as BC (Muslim) and obtain community certificates under one of the seven notified Muslim communities for the purpose of availing reservation benefits.

A division bench of Justices GR Swaminathan and PB Balaji struck down the GO and held that it was contrary to binding judicial precedents of both the Supreme Court and the Madras High Court.

The high court had observed that a person converting to Islam could only be treated as a Muslim and could not, by virtue of conversion alone, be classified as belonging to any specific notified Backward Class Muslim community for reservation purposes.

The judgment arose from a petition filed by Sameer Ahamed, who converted from Hinduism to Islam in 2015, with the conversion being notified through a Gazette notification in 2016.

He subsequently married according to Islamic rites and sought a certificate identifying him as belonging to the "Muslim Lebba'i" community to avail reservation benefits. His application was rejected by the tahsildar, prompting him to move the high court. (PTI)

Calcutta HC adjourns hearing in TMC bank accounts' case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The private bank where three bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress party have been debit-frozen filed a report before the Calcutta High Court on Wednesday as per its direction to disclose the corpus held in those accounts.

Taking note of personal difficulty expressed by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who is representing the Bidhannagar police in this matter, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya adjourned the hearing until Thursday.

Hearing a petition by the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the TMC challenging the debit-freeze of the party's three bank accounts, Justice Bhattacharyya had on July 2 directed the private bank to disclose the corpus held in



those accounts. The court did not open the report which was submitted because the hearing was adjourned.

Bringing to the court's notice that a few more bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress have also been debit-frozen, the Mamata Banerjee-led faction's lawyer Kishore Dutta stated that he will file a supplementary affidavit in this regard on the next date of hearing.

Justice Bhattacharyya said



Delhi court slams CBI, directs defreezing of bank accounts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that the freezing of bank accounts of without a direct link to a crime is "draconian", a Delhi court has directed the CBI to defreeze three accounts of an individual whose son-in-law is an accused in a ₹3-crore bribery case.

Slamming the agency for its "completely arbitrary" action of freezing the accounts, the court said the probe of the alleged offences "cannot be made a tool for harassing ordinary citizenry only because their relatives are suspected of having committed certain offences".

Special Judge Sushant Changotra was hearing the plea of one Gulshan Kumar, moved by his advocate Prateek Som, challenging the freezing of his three bank accounts as illegal.

In an order passed on Tuesday, the court said, "In

the application at hand, the applicant (Gulshan) is the father-in-law of one of the accused."

It said according to the CBI, the applicant was not involved in the entire sequence of events relating to the demand, acceptance or transportation of the bribe amount. The court also said the investigating officer (IO) had not recorded any reasons for freezing the bank accounts.

While the CBI alleged that the applicant aided his absconding son-in-law's concealment, the court observed a discrepancy that the accused was arrested on June 16, yet Gulshan's accounts were not frozen until two days later.

Judge Changotra said, "The investigating agency can proceed to freeze bank accounts of individuals, but it has to be done with the object of safeguarding and preventing the loss of proceeds of crime."



He said that in the present case, there was apparently no connection between the proceeds of crime and the bank accounts of the applicant, and there was not "a whisper of allegation" that accused Prabhat Kumar (Kapoor) had transferred any amount to his father-in-

law's account after an alleged conspiracy meeting on May 14.

On June 2, while rejecting the CBI's plea seeking further custodial interrogation of Haryana cadre IPS officer Deepak Gahlawat, arrested in the alleged bribery case linked to the agency's probe into a fake

drug manufacturing racket, the court had also noted that there were no financial transactions in Gahlawat's bank account after a conspiratorial meeting with other co-accused persons on May 14.

In its order, the court highlighted that before freezing the bank accounts of an individual, the IO must have a reasonable basis to assume that the bank account was used directly or indirectly in receiving or layering the proceeds of crime.

But in this case, the court said that the CBI did not even have the statements of accounts before taking the "arbitrary decision" to freeze them.

"The arbitrary exercise of the above-mentioned discretion in freezing the bank accounts of individuals who do not have any direct or remote connection with the commission of offences is completely dra-

conian in nature, and the investigating agency cannot proceed to arbitrarily attach/freeze/seize the bank accounts or other valuable assets of individuals on their whims," the court said.

Deprecating the action, it said that an investigating agency is bound to act within the four corners of the law and the probe of the alleged offences "cannot be made a tool for harassing ordinary citizenry only because their relatives are suspected of having committed certain offences".

"It is extremely important that such draconian and arbitrary practices are shunned to protect the valuable rights of law-abiding citizens," the court said.

It said that prima facie the freezing of Gulshan's bank accounts was "completely arbitrary and devoid of any plausible explanation".

The court then directed the defreezing of the three bank accounts.

Chhattisgarh HC dismisses plea against Saraswati Vandana prayer directive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bilsalpur

The Chhattisgarh High Court has dismissed a petition against the state's directive introducing the recitation of Saraswati Vandana and Gayatri Mantra in Government schools, noting the order contains no mandatory or coercive direction compelling students to act against their faith. A single bench of Justice Amitendra Kishore Prasad, in the judgment on July 2, termed the petition premature.

The judgment was uploaded on the HC's website on Tuesday.

The petition, filed by three persons, challenged a June 12 circular issued by the state's School Education Department directing all schools under it to conduct a series of daily cultural, educational and value-based activities from the 2026-27 academic session. The circular directed the recitation of the national anthem, national song, deep mantra, Saraswati Vandana, Guru Mantra, Shanti Mantra and accounts of the lives of great personalities during the morning assembly, and the state song, Gayatri Mantra and Shanti Mantra at the close of the school day.

The petitioners claimed the directive violated Articles 14, 21, 25, 28(1), 29 and 30 of the Constitution, arguing that stu-



dents from minority communities could feel compelled to participate in religious practices not belonging to their faith.

Aamir Khan, counsel for the petitioners, submitted in the HC that educational institutions wholly funded by the state cannot enforce prayers associated with a particular religion, as doing so would be contrary to the constitutional principle of secularism.

The petitioners asserted that the chanting of Saraswati Vandana, Gayatri Mantra, Guru Mantra and Shanti Mantra amounts to imparting religious instructions and promoting a particular religion in Government schools, which is constitutionally barred.

Khan argued that compelling students to recite such mantras would infringe upon their freedom of conscience and religion, forcing them either to act against their beliefs or forego their education.

Opposing the plea, Deputy Advocate General Anand Dadariya argued that the petition was politically motivated and based on speculative apprehensions rather than any concrete injury.

He submitted that the June 12 circular was in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and sought to promote Indian knowledge systems and cultural awareness.

The state Government has merely operationalised these national pedagogical goals within its valid executive domain under Article 162 of the Constitution. Such policy measures cannot be labelled as unconstitutional or communal, he said. The state also informed the court that the policy had already been implemented across Government schools without any complaint from students, parents or teachers.

SC agrees to hear plea filed by CBSE class 9 students from Gulf countries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to hear a plea challenging the CBSE's March 27 assessment scheme for regular students who were affected by the cancellation of Class XII board examination in Gulf countries due to the Iran-US war.

A bench of Justices KV Viswanathan and Alok Aradhe sought responses from the Centre and the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on the plea filed by 30 regular students from Gulf countries.

The bench also sought responses from the Centre and the CBSE on a separate plea filed by a Class XII student from a Gulf country challenging the June 21 notification on the assessment of private candidates affected by the cancellation of examinations.

Advocate Raj Kishor Choudhary, who appeared for the petitioners, told the bench that students were not satisfied with the assessment scheme.

While issuing notice on the petitions, the bench said that a copy of the pleas should also be served on the



office of Solicitor General Tushar Mehta.

It posted the matter for hearing on July 14.

Advocate Vineet Jindal also appeared for the petitioners. The plea filed by 30 students sought quashing of and/or suitably modifying the March 27, 2026 assessment scheme. It also sought a direction to the authorities to adopt a fair, transparent and non-discriminatory evaluation mechanism.

Besides several other directions, it urged that the CBSE be directed to conduct a special fresh examination and special improvement examination for affected students in all subjects, without any restriction on the number of subjects that may be opted for, and to permit such students to retain whichever result is more

beneficial to them.

On June 22, the Centre had informed the apex court that the CBSE has come up with a new policy for the evaluation of private students who were affected by the cancellation of Class XII board examination in Gulf countries due to the war.

The Solicitor General, appearing for the Centre and the CBSE, had said that a fresh all-India policy was framed to address the concerns of similarly situated students affected by the cancellation of examinations in the Gulf countries due to the regional conflict.

The top law officer had said that under the new policy, which was notified on June 21, a distinct formula for evaluating private students appearing for the board exam was developed.

Delhi extortion case: HC seeks police stand on plea by Suresh aide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday sought Delhi Police's stand on a petition by a close aide of alleged fraudster Suresh Chandrasekhar, challenging the framing of charges against her in a ₹200 crore extortion case.

The trial court on June 3 framed charges against Chandrasekhar, Pinky Irani and 19 others for various offences, including under the stringent MCOCA provisions.

Justice Madhu Jain issued notice to Delhi Police on Irani's revision petition assailing the trial court order and granted two weeks to the investigating agency to file its response.

The bench also issued notice on Irani's plea seeking a stay on the trial court proceedings and listed the matter for further hearing on September 10.

Irani's counsel argued that she has been wrongly charged in the case, asserting that there was no basis to sustain the MCOCA provisions against her.

He submitted that MCOCA could be invoked when there is an involvement in an IPC offence, which was admitted not the case here. MCOCA, or the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act, 1999, is a law enacted to combat organised crime syndicates and terrorism.

The act equips authorities with special powers to track,



intercept and penalise gang-related criminal activities that normal penal codes fail to deter.

Delhi Police's senior counsel opposed the petition and sought time to file response.

The trial court earlier ordered framing of charges

members of an organised crime syndicate.

Charges were directed to be framed against other accused persons as well for various penal offences, and under the IT Act and MCOCA provisions for committing organised crime.

The police's charge sheet has alleged that Irani used to portray Chandrasekhar as a business tycoon and was instrumental in facilitating his meetings with certain Bollywood personalities.

It has stated that the police had recorded the statements of several people, including Bollywood actors Jacqueline Fernandez and Nora Fatehi. A Chandrasekhar, who is currently in jail, is accused of cheating many people,

including high-profile individuals such as former Fortis Healthcare promoter Shivinder Mohan Singh's wife Aditi Singh.

Police has alleged that Chandrasekhar and his associates reportedly took money from Aditi after posing as Government officials and promising to secure bail for her husband who was in jail in a money laundering case.

Chandrasekhar reportedly persuaded Aditi to transfer money by impersonating as a central Government official over a spoof call while he was lodged in Rohini jail and promised to manage bail for her husband, it alleged.

The high court had granted bail to Irani in the case on October 20, 2023.

Kerala HC issues contempt notice to bureaucrat over sanction order in KSCDC graft case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court on Wednesday issued a contempt notice to a bureaucrat over the contents of a Government order granting sanction to the CBI to prosecute KSCDC officials in a 2015 corruption case.

Justice A Badharudeen said he would not spare the official concerned, as the order granting sanction to prosecute several accused, including former KSCDC chairman R Chandrasekharan, who is also the state president of the Indian National Trade Union Congress, appeared to blame the judiciary. The court was referring to the contents of an earlier sanction order issued by the Government on July 2.



The Government had subsequently issued a fresh sanction order on July 6.

"Both disciplinary and contempt action should be taken against him (the official). I won't spare this man from contempt proceedings. He will be proceeded against. Strict action will be taken. There will be no leniency.

There is no question of accepting an apology," Justice Badharudeen said, referring to the first sanction order.

The court also observed that the official — K Biju — appeared to be trying to save the accused in the case "for reasons known to him".

"That is the dangerous aspect of the order. How can

an IAS officer say such things? He is saying the sanction order was passed because the court said so. It was an order to be issued based on the facts, dehors the prosecution records, and on primary satisfaction on merits. It was not to be issued based on what the court said," the judge observed. The court said that it was not a sanction order but one intended to "target the judiciary and the system".

"It is a very dangerous attitude on the part of the officer," it said, and ordered the personal appearance of the official on the next date of hearing, July 10. The court said the official should state in person why contempt of court proceedings should not be initiated against him.

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India, ASEAN assess progress of FTA talks

India and the 11-nation ASEAN bloc on Tuesday took stock of the progress of talks for the review of free trade agreement in goods between the two sides, the commerce ministry said on Wednesday. The India-ASEAN free trade agreement in goods was signed in 2009. ASEAN is a key trade partner of India with about 11 per cent share in India's global trade. The progress of talks was reviewed during the 13th ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement (AITIGA) Joint Committee (JC) and related meetings here. "The Joint Committee provided strategic guidance to the Sub-Committees in their respective areas of work and urged them to expedite the finalisation of the outstanding chapters under the AITIGA review," it said. Bilateral trade between India and ASEAN reached USD 128 billion in 2025-26. (PTI)

Flipkart scraps ₹1,000 price cap to offer zero commission on fashion

E-commerce marketplace Flipkart has extended its zero-commission policy to include all products within its fashion category, removing the previous price cap of ₹1,000. The move will allow around 90,000 transacting sellers in the fashion segment to retain full margins, Flipkart said in a statement on Wednesday. Previously, the platform applied the zero-commission policy only to fashion items priced up to ₹1,000. "By extending this seller-first initiative across the entire fashion category, we are making a long-term investment in our sellers so they can invest more confidently in innovation, assortment expansion and brand building," Kapil Thirani, Vice President of Flipkart Fashion, said. Established in 2007, Flipkart has a registered user base of over 500 million and hosts more than 1.4 million sellers on its platform. (PTI)

SEBI amends registration fee rule for FPIs; directs payment in rupee terms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Markets regulator SEBI has replaced the existing US dollar-denominated registration fee for Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) with a rupee-based fee structure.

To implement the change, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has amended the rules governing FPIs. The revised provisions will come into effect after six months, SEBI said in its notification dated July 3.

As per the notification, the regulator has revised the reg-

istration fee for Category-I FPIs from \$2,500 to ₹2.3 lakh. Similarly, registration fee for FPIs belonging to Category II has been revised from \$250

Gold falls ₹2,308/10g in futures on strong dollar, higher crude oil

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Gold futures slumped by Rs 2,308 to Rs 1.43 lakh per 10 grams on Wednesday, tracking losses in global markets as a rally in crude oil rates dented the appeal of the precious metal amid escalating tensions in West Asia.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for August delivery declined by ₹2,308, or 1.59 per cent, to ₹1,43,084 per 10 grams in a business turnover of 10,440 lots.

Traders said rising crude oil prices following fresh hostilities in West Asia stoked inflation concerns, strengthening the US dollar and prompting investors to trim exposure

to precious metals.

"Gold prices traded lower in the domestic markets on Wednesday amid renewed geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, and concerns over potential supply disruptions through the Strait of Hormuz boosted oil prices and strengthened the US

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS11

Stock markets slump 2% as US-Iran tensions rise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled over 2 per cent on Wednesday after US President Donald Trump said the interim agreement with Iran is over, leading to a sharp rally in crude oil prices.

Besides, investors shifted to a risk-off mode following pre-earnings anxiety over sluggish first-quarter forecasts amid a negative trend in global markets, traders said. The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent, to settle at 76,503.60. During the day, it plummeted 1,921.69 points, or 2.45 per cent, to 76,259.03.

A total of 3,211 stocks declined, while 1,070 advanced and 173 remained unchanged on the BSE. On similar lines, the 50-share NSE Nifty tumbled 516.65 points, or 2.12 per cent, to end at 23,882.05.

"Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp sell-off as US President Donald Trump declared the interim peace deal with Iran is 'over' following Iranian attacks on commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, reigniting geopolitical tensions and raising fresh

concerns over global energy supplies," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm.

The renewed escalation triggered a sharp rebound in crude oil prices, which surged nearly 7 per cent, sending shockwaves across global

financial markets, he added.

All firms in the Sensex pack ended in the red. InterGlobe Aviation, Maruti, Hindustan Unilever, Bajaj Finance, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Mahindra & Mahindra were major laggards.

Oil marketing companies, paint makers, aviation stocks tumble as crude oil prices jump

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Shares of oil marketing companies, paint manufacturers and aviation firms ended lower on Wednesday following a sharp surge in crude oil prices amid fresh tensions between the US and Iran.

The stock of Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd tumbled 4.60 per cent, Indian Oil Corporation dropped 3.51 per cent and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd declined 3.20 per cent on BSE.

Among aviation firms, shares of InterGlobe Aviation tumbled 5.02 per cent and Spicejet declined 3.04 per cent.

The stock of Shalimar Paints

dropped 4.44 per cent, Indigo Paints fell by 4.18 per cent, Asian Paints edged lower by 2.49 per cent, Berger Paints dipped 2.26 per cent and Kansai Nerolac Paints slipped 1.95 per cent.

Crude oil is a key raw material for paint manufacturing companies.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 6.18 per cent to \$78.74 per barrel.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent, to settle at 76,503.60. On similar lines, the 50-share NSE Nifty tumbled 516.65 points, or 2.12 per cent, to end at 23,882.05.

"Markets witnessed a sharp sell-

off on Wednesday, with benchmark indices posting their steepest single-day decline in over two months amid adverse global cues. The sharp decline was triggered by renewed geopolitical tensions after the US President indicated that the US-Iran peace deal is 'over', reigniting concerns over a prolonged conflict in the Middle East," said Ajit Mishra — SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd.

The escalation pushed Brent crude prices sharply higher, reviving worries over inflation and its potential impact on India's macro-economic outlook, he added.

Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich

Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said, "Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp sell-off as US President Donald Trump declared the interim peace deal with Iran is 'over' following Iranian attacks on commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, reigniting geopolitical tensions and raising fresh concerns over global energy supplies."

Energy markets also came under renewed pressure as the escalating conflict heightened concerns over potential disruptions to crude oil supplies through the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical energy transit routes, he added.

Rupee tanks 59 paise to close at 95.55 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The rupee tanked 59 paise to settle at 95.55 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday as the US launched fresh strikes on Iran after Tehran struck three ships in the Strait of Hormuz, pushing up crude oil prices and strengthening the dollar.

The US military attacked Iran early Wednesday after it said Tehran struck three ships in the Strait of Hormuz, part

of an American effort that also revoked the Islamic Republic's ability to openly sell crude oil in the world market. Iran retaliated with strikes targeting Bahrain and Kuwait. Following the strikes, global crude oil prices rose exponentially. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 6.16 per cent at \$78.73 per barrel in futures trade.

Weak domestic equity markets further weighed on the local unit, according to

forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.15 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 94.98-95.61 during the day. It eventually settled at 95.55 (provisional), down 59 paise from its previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee appreciated 47 paise to close at 94.96 against the US dollar.

"The rupee opened weaker against the dollar and continued to remain volatile intra-

day... the dollar was bought on dips as the equity markets were down and dollar index was up. Overall, today's rupee weakness was externally driven, mainly by higher crude oil prices, stronger US dollar, and geopolitical uncertainty," Anil Kumar Bhansali, Head of Treasury and Executive Director, Finrex Treasury Advisors LLP, said.

The rupee is expected to remain in the range of 95.25 to 96.00 on Thursday, he added. Meanwhile, the dollar

index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 101.13, up 0.11 per cent.

On the domestic equity market front, Sensex crashed 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent, to 76,503.60, while Nifty plummeted 516.65 points, or 2.12 per cent, to 23,882.05.

Foreign institutional investors purchased equities worth Rs 393.19 crore on a net basis on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

Monsoon rains to pick up in July, boost kharif crop sowing: Shivraj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Monsoon rains are expected to strengthen in July, aiding the sowing of kharif crops after a slow start to the season, Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said on Wednesday.

The overall rainfall deficit narrowed to 24 per cent in July from 33 per cent in June, Chouhan told reporters after a high-level review meeting. The number of rainfall-deficient districts fell to 178 from 262 as several parts of the country received good rain in recent days, he said.

The government is closely monitoring the situation in 13 states, including Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Bihar, Jharkhand, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Punjab, West Bengal and Odisha, Chouhan said.

IMF pares India's growth forecast to 6.4% for 2027 fiscal from 6.5% in April

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

India's economy is expected to grow at 6.4 per cent in fiscal year 2027, a tad slower than the 6.5 per cent projected in April, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) said on Wednesday. The IMF, in its update to the World Economic Outlook (WEO), projected India to grow at 6.7 per cent in fiscal year 2028, an increase of 20 basis points from the 6.5 per cent growth projected in April.

"India remains among the fastest growing major economies, with growth projected at 6.4 per cent supported by strong momentum in

private consumption and services activity," the IMF said.

"Factors that are underpinning the forecast revisions are basically twofold. On the upside, we have the better-than-expected out turn in the most recent data, but we also have high-frequency indicators through April showing quite a bit of resilience in overall econom-

ic activity," Deniz Igan, Division Chief (World Economic Studies), told reporters here on projections for India. But these positive effects are then more than offset for 2026 by the higher energy prices in the baseline and in the July update, as well as the greater pass-through of those higher oil prices to prices at the pump in India, she said.

"Moving into 2027, the IMF expects a strengthening of the economy with the energy shock dissipating and medium-term growth being estimated at around 6.5 per cent, and output closing we expect some pickup there," Igan added. (PTI)

FROM THE WORLD

BANGLADESH5 children die in landslide

A landslide caused by monsoon rains killed at least five children as it swept through an Islamic school at a camp for Rohingya refugees in Bangladesh's southeastern Cox's Bazar district, a fire official said. More than 1 million refugees live in the camp. Dollar Tripura, local chief of the Fire Service and Civil Defence, said the landslide hit as children were attending classes.

Tripura said they rescued another five injured children but suspected that more could be buried. The rescue operation continued Wednesday evening. Three days earlier, landslides killed at least eight people at Rohingya camps in the area. The weather office in the South Asian nation's capital, Dhaka, forecast more rain in the coming days. (PTI)

UK

Woman hanged gets pardon

The last woman to be hanged in the UK on the charge of murdering her boyfriend was on Wednesday granted a conditional pardon after more than 70 years by King Charles III, on the advice of the British Government.

Russian strikes kill 4 in Kyiv; Ukraine hits oil hubs

ILLIA NOVIKOV Kyiv

Russian drones and missiles killed four people across Ukraine on Wednesday in attacks before dawn and at midday, as Moscow kept up its pressure on the capital of Kyiv in the latest phase of the over 4-year-old war.

Ukraine struck oil refineries in Russia's Saratov and Tatarstan regions, according to President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who was in Turkey to meet with US President Donald Trump on the sidelines of the NATO summit.

Answering reporters' questions with Zelenskyy, Trump said the US would give licenses so that Patriot air defence systems can be made overseas for Ukraine to counter



Rescue workers search for victims after a Russian air attack in Kharkiv, Ukraine

AP

Russia. Zelenskyy thanked Trump for his support and said Kyiv wanted to discuss weapons supplies, possible peace negotiations and a developing drone deal.

"Air defence is the priority," Zelenskyy said, adding that Kyiv wanted to share details of its needs under the Prioritised Ukraine Requirements List, or PURL, in which European allies and Canada are buying American weapons to help his country.

Zelenskyy also said Ukrainian and US officials had begun work on a drone deal, calling it "a very good beginning." Russia attacks Kyiv, hours apart In Kyiv, several explosions were heard shortly after midnight, even before authorities could

issue an air raid alert to give civilians time to find shelter.

The early morning Russian attacks killed one woman and injured two others in Kyiv, according to city administration head Tymur Tkachenko. The State Emergency Service said the attack damaged several administrative buildings and warehouses, as well as a garage complex and several trams.

Hours later, another Russian drone struck Desnianskyi district, killing a second person, Tkachenko said. A total of eight people were injured in the Russian attacks on the Capital.

In Kharkiv, two people were killed and 20 others were injured in a series of overnight strikes, according to Mayor

Ihor Terekhov. In Zaporizhzhia, Russian guided bomb injured a man and a woman Tuesday night, regional head Ivan Fedorov said. Ukraine's air force says Russia fired 169 long-range strike drones and seven missiles, including five ballistic missiles. Air defences shot down or jammed 139 drones, and two anti-radar missiles didn't reach their targets, it said.

All five ballistic missiles and 20 drones struck targets at 15 locations, the air force said, underscoring the continued strain on Ukraine's air defences. Russia's Defence Ministry said it struck an arms industry facilities in Kyiv, hitting a plant that manufactures components for Flamingo cruise missiles. (AP)

Sri Lanka former president Wickremesinghe awaits indictment

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Colombo

The next hearing in the case of misusing public funds against former president Ranil Wickremesinghe will take place on September 30, a Sri Lankan court announced on Wednesday.

Wickremesinghe became the first president to be arrested after he was accused of misusing public funds to attend a graduation of his wife Maithri Wickremesinghe at the Wolverhampton University in the UK in 2023.

Drone strikes on civilian vehicles kill 20 in Sudan, say rights groups

FATMA KHALED Cairo

Drone strikes on civilian vehicles headed to social gatherings in Sudan have killed over 20 people in recent days, according to rights groups, as the use of unmanned aircraft becomes increasingly common in the north eastern African country's war.

A drone hit the outskirts of Khartoum killing 10 civilians, including five women from the same family, as they drove to a wedding, the Sudan Doctors Network said on Wednesday. The medical aid group, which has been tracking violence between the military and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces throughout the war - which



is in its fourth year - blamed Tuesday's attack on a road west of Omdurman, the sister city of the capital, Khartoum, on the RSF. All of

those on the vehicle, which caught fire, were killed.

The group said that the strike "was deliberate and carried out using a guided

drone" and called for the international community to pressure RSF leadership to stop targeting civilians. A separate drone strike on

Tuesday hit a transport vehicle near a water facility in the province, killing two people, according to Emergency Lawyers, which tracks violence in Sudan.

The previous day, 13 civilians, including five women, were killed when a drone hit their vehicle as they headed to a wedding in a al-Shaatout town, in North Kordofan province, Emergency Lawyers said.

"This attack is part of an escalating pattern of drone attacks on civilians as drones continue to fly over the northern parts of the province... monitoring residents' movements," the group said in a statement.

North Kordofan has seen a surge in drone strikes amid

repeated international concerns about the RSF closing in on the strategic city of el-Obeid, which is home to the army's 5th Infantry Division.

Drone strikes on the city have destroyed civilian infrastructure, including power facilities and neighbourhoods, and targeted bridges and key supply routes, according to the UN.

The war in Sudan, which started in April 2023 after long-simmering tensions between the army and the RSF, has killed at least 59,000 people, displaced some 13 million and pushed many parts of the country into famine. More than 30 million people are in need of humanitarian assistance. (AP)

SMFG Grihashakti

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspiro BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051. Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN.

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002. NOTICE is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	LAN : 616539511374111 1. Roop Singh S/o. Jawahar Singh 2. Mihalesh Devi W/o. Roop Singh,	Plot No. 226 , Measuring Area 83.61 Sq.Mtrs Land Bearing Kharsa No. 220, Girraj Vatika , Mauza Ronchi Bangur, Tehsil And District Mathura East :- Plot No. 191, West Rasta 18 Feet Wide North Plot No. 225 , South Plot No. 227	Rs. 28,10,000/-	29.07.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	28.07.2026
			Rs. 2,81,000/-		
2.	LAN : 616539511519613 1. Sameer Khan S/o. Anwar Khan 2. Anwar Khan, 3. Nagina, W/o. Anwar Khan	A Shop Measuring Area 15.53 Sq.Mtrs .Shop No. 105 First Floor , Mohalla Govind Nagar Masani Tehsil & Distt. Mathura,Up East :- Shop No.104, West :- Shop No.106, North Land Lord Frim, South :- Road Shop Gallery	Rs. 10,40,000/-	29.07.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	28.07.2026
			Rs. 1,04,000/-		

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also contact : **Pankaj Kumar, Mobile: 7380950199, E-mail : Pankaj.Kumar38@grihashakti.com, Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com**

Place : Mathura, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 08.07.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is for the information of general public that our clients, Sh. Ashok Sehgal (Father) and Smt. Meenu Sehgal (Mother), R/o Z-66, Dayal Sar Road, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110056, along with their son Sh. Dinesh Sehgal (Elder Brother) and daughter Ms. Himanshi Sehgal (Younger Sister), do hereby declare that they have disowned their daughter/ sister, namely Ms. Bhanu Sehgal, from their family due to her disrespectful conduct and marrying against the wishes of our clients. Our clients have severed all relations with Ms. Bhanu Sehgal and her husband. Any person dealing with Ms. Bhanu Sehgal or her husband shall do so entirely at his/ her own risk, and our clients and shall not be responsible or liable for any of their acts, deeds, transactions, liabilities, debts, obligations or any civil or criminal consequences arising therefrom. **Jatin Nanda (Advocate)**
Enrolment No. D/3051/2018

Gennext Insurance Brokers Private Limited

Policyworld

Office Shifting Intimation

We hereby intimate our policy holders that our branch has been shifted to the following location:

New Address:

101A, 1st Floor,
Vipul Agora Mall, Gurgaon,
Haryana-122002,

DIRECT INSURANCE BROKER -
LIFE AND GENERAL
License Number: 501,
Valid till: 19/11/2026

The Pioneer

Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, Jatin Verma, have lost the possession letter issued by Amrapali Group pertaining to my property No AM-208, Amrapali Village, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh -201014, If anyone found please contact me at 9971022221.

PD(090)C

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Angana, D/o Biswa Ranjan Bhattacharjee, W/o Ashish Kumar Dubey, R/o 901, Tower-1, Panchsheel Pebbles, Sector-3, Vaishali, Ghaziabad-201010,(UP) have changed my name from Angana to Angana Bhattacharjee. Henceforth i would be known by the name of Angana Bhattacharjee for all future purposes.

PD(089)C

I, Ravinder Nath Bose S/o Kali Podo Bose R/o B-53 Malikpur Village, Delhi-110009 have changed my name to Rabindra Nath Bose.

PD(088)C

I , DURGA DEVI , W/O , MANISH BANSAL R/O , C-576 , GALI NUMBER - 9 , MAJLIS PARK AZADPUR DELHI -110033 , HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SRISHTI BANSAL AFTER MARRIAGE.

PD(091)C

I, Deepika, W/O-No.4201185F Hav Harish Singh, R/o- Vill- Shyalter, PO-Ghighrani, Distt- Pithoragarh, Teh- Didihat, Uttarakhand-262543, have changed my name from Deepika to Deepika Airy, vide affidavit dated 08/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(092)C

I, Bbraj Mohan Prasad S, Father of JC-781655W Nb/Sub Priya Ranjan Kumar, R/o- Vill- Surhatha, Post- Bibipur, Dist- Vaishali, Bihar-844111, have changed my name from Bbraj Mohan Prasad S to Braj Mohan Prasad Singh, vide affidavit dated 08/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(093)C

I, No. 2701723A Hav Upesh Kumar Singh R/o Vpo- Kauria, Teh-Maharajganj, Dist- Siwan, Bihar-841406 declare that my mother's name is wrongly mentioned as Aasha Devi in my service records and her correct name is ASHA DEVI for all future purposes vide affidavit before Public Notary Delhi 08-07-2026.

PD(094)C

I, Bitu Kumar Singh, S/o No.14658386K Hav Santosh Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Chhota Sasaram, Teh- Udwant Nagar, Dist- Bhojpur, Bihar- 802157, have changed my name from Bitu Kumar Singh to Bittu Kumar Singh, vide affidavit No. IN-DL487696313355777Y, dated 08/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(095)C

I Vaibhav Kumar Rana S/o Sudesh Rana R/o Plot No-50 Kh.No-65/13 Nangli Vihar Extn Ph-2 Bapraula Delhi-110043 have changed my name to Vaibhav Kumar Ranaa.

PD(096)C

I, Samta, D/o Sh. Satpal Ailawadhi R/o A-1 Flat No -4, Sector-5 Rohini Delhi-110085, Declared that in my 10th marksheet my name is wrongly written samta Rani and have changed my name from samta Rani to samta for all purposes.

PD(097)C

54 terrorists, 38 security personnel killed in Balochistan over four days

SAJJAD HUSSAIN Islamabad/Karachi

At least 54 terrorists, 38 security personnel and four civilians were killed during the last four days in various incidents in the restive Balochistan province, the ISPR said on Wednesday. The trouble began on the night of July 4 and 5 when Fitna al Khawarij terrorists attacked the innocent local population in Hanna Urak, Director General Lt Gen Ahmed Sharif Chaudhry of the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), military's media wing, told a press conference at Rawalpindi.

The state uses the term Fitna al-Khawarij to refer to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and its affiliates. Four civilians were killed and six injured during that incident, he said. In the second incident, terrorists late Monday night carried out a multi-directional attack on a police check post, set up to guard a Pumping Station in Mangi Dam in Ziarat district, in which nine policemen, including two station house officers (SHOs),



were killed. At least 15 terrorists were killed in a retaliatory clearance operation following the attack, the ISPR DG said.

Several police officials were taken as hostages, making the subsequent operation by paramilitary Frontier Corps, army personnel and other law enforcement agencies (LEAs) complicated, he said. (PTI)

Jaishankar meets Kuwaiti crown Prince to boost ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Kuwait City

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Wednesday met Kuwait's Crown Prince Sheikh Sabah Al-Khaled Al-Sabah and the two leaders discussed ways to enhance the bilateral cooperation in various fields as well as developments in West Asia.

In a social media post, Jaishankar said he conveyed the greetings of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the Crown Prince. "Deeply appreciate his commitment to take forward our bilateral cooperation. Thank him for his sharing of perspectives on developments in the Gulf," the minister said. In a post on X, the Kuwaiti Foreign Ministry said that the two leaders discussed historical ties between the two coun-



tries and ways to enhance bilateral cooperation in various fields. Jaishankar also met his Kuwaiti counterpart Sheikh Jarrah Jaber Al-Ahmad Al-Sabah and reviewed bilateral ties. They discussed ways to strengthen and develop cooperation in various fields, it added. The two sides also discussed the latest regional and international developments, it added. The Kuwaiti foreign minister also hosted a luncheon in honour of Jaishankar and the accompa-

nying delegation. Jaishankar arrived in Kuwait on Tuesday and was received at the airport by Deputy Foreign Minister Hamad Suleiman Mashaan Al-Mashaan.

The minister is on a visit covering Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait and Oman from July 5 to 10. The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

Sri Lanka to establish prison in former hospital after riot kills 28

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Colombo

Sri Lanka has initiated steps to establish a new prison complex at an abandoned hospital near the southern port city of Galle following a two-day riot at the Negombo prison that left 28 people dead, officials said on Wednesday.

The violence at the Negombo prison on July 5



and 6 that killed 28 people, including eight prison officials, was triggered by a dispute between rival groups of inmates over drugs. Severe

overcrowding became a major factor that prevented authorities from containing the clashes, officials said.

The death toll rose from 27 to 28 on Wednesday. The prison at Negombo - a coastal city about 35-odd kilometres north of Colombo - housed around 2,400 inmates at the time of the riot against its sanctioned capacity of 700, the prisoners' rights organisation said.

BRIEFLY

Naomi Osaka laments sore feet and getting old



Sure, Naomi Osaka is a four-time Grand Slam champion who also impresses with her fashionable outfits. On Tuesday, she sounded like the rest of us. The plantar fasciitis was acting up. She's working too much. "I'm just getting old," Osaka said. The 28-year-old Osaka's Wimbledon run and fashion show ended in a 7-6(4) 6-4 loss to Karolina Muchova in the quarterfinals of the grass-court Grand Slam.

Osaka, a former No. 1 player, had ousted top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka in the fourth round – with arguably some of her best tennis since returning from maternity leave – but couldn't find her rhythm Tuesday against her Czech opponent. "It's hard because I played so well in my last match, then today I just feel like I didn't play well at all and I didn't have any energy," said Osaka, who despite the loss still had her best result at the All England Club by reaching the quarterfinals. "I could feel it coming because I've played way more matches than I usually do before a Slam," she added. "I just wanted to try that to see the rhythm, you know? Obviously it worked out well. But I think I probably won't do that again. But yeah, I would say it was like an accumulation of playing two weeks straight without a day off."

(AP)

A Cairo coffee house erupts, then goes silent



The small coffee house in Cairo turned into a tiny stadium. Several hundred people, mostly men and boys as young as 7, gathered around wall-mounted screens ahead of the kickoff whistle. The scene played out across the soccer-mad nation as Egypt faced the defending World Cup champion in the round-of-16 fixture in Atlanta. It was a historic day for millions of Egyptians even after their national team's adventure reached its end with Tuesday's 2-3 loss to Argentina. "It's a brutal scenario," Ahmed Saadany, a teacher, reflected after the game. "The journey shouldn't have ended that way." With their own star Mohamed Salah, Egypt reached the round of 16 by beating Australia 4-2 on penalty kicks after a 1-1 draw in the round of 32 on Friday. The Pharaohs advanced to the knockout stages – their first ever – after securing the second place in the Group G, behind Belgium.

(AP)

Egypt seething after squandering two-goal lead and losing to Lionel Messi's Argentina



PAUL NEWBERRY ■ Atlanta

For Mohamed Salah and Egypt, what could have been a glorious celebration turned ugly at the end. On the cusp of upsetting the defending World Cup champion, the Pharaohs squandered a two-goal lead late in the game and fell to Lionel Messi and Argentina 3-2 in the round of 16 on Tuesday. The winning tally came two minutes into stoppage time and set off a wild scene in front of the Egyptian bench. A red card was shown to goalkeeping coach Saafan Elsaghir, who had to be physically restrained from going after French referee Francois Letexier. Multiple yellow cards were doled out to those griping vehemently about Argentina's final goal.

Egypt coach Hossam Hassan held up both arms in an "X" shape – the signal in soccer for calling out racial abuse – and stated flatly that his upstart squad was victimised by a soccer establishment that wanted Messi and Argentina to advance to the quarterfinals in their pursuit of a second straight title.

"We have been treated unfairly

today," Hassan said. "We have suffered injustice."

In a tournament already marred by allegations that U.S. President Donald Trump influenced FIFA to overturn a one-game suspension for an American player, Egypt turned up the heat on soccer's governing body. "I just would like to say that we would have deserved to earn this win," Hassan said, "but we are leaving with honor, with pride, regardless of this defeat."

Hassan, who has been outspoken in his support of the Palestinians during the tournament, was upset that a potential second goal was overturned by a video review that showed a foul by Egypt at the start of an end-to-end play. Egypt took a 2-0 lead anyway on Mostafa Zico's goal in the 67th minute, but there was still enough time for Argentina to pull off a comeback for the ages in the stadium that is normally the home of NFL's Atlanta Falcons.

Cristian Romero gave the champions hope in the 79th. Messi blasted in the tying goal off the crossbar just four minutes later. And Enzo Fernandez won it for

Argentina in the second minute of stoppage time – a play that began at the opposite end of the field with Salah being stripped of the ball as he tried to dribble into the penalty area, winding up face down on the turf. "The Egyptian Football Association cannot remain silent regarding the refereeing decisions witnessed during the match against Argentina as well as the failure to make appropriate use of the Video Assistant Referee (VAR) system," the EFA said in a statement Wednesday morning. "Several key incidents raised serious concerns and left profound questions about the consistency and fairness of decisions that directly influenced the course of the game."

Even retired NFL quarterback Tom Brady took note of the comeback, going on social media to point out this rivaled the one he pulled off against the Falcons in the Super Bowl on Feb. 5, 2017, when the New England Patriots rallied from a 28-3 deficit late in the third quarter to win 34-28 in overtime. "Yeah so that might top 28-3," Brady wrote on X.

(AP)

EU lawmakers call for investigation into FIFA boss

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Brussels

Dozens of European lawmakers are gathering support to launch an investigation in the European Parliament of FIFA boss Gianni Infantino over his involvement in the decision to permit US striker Folarin Balogun to play despite an earlier red card.

Balogun was shown a red card during the US victory over Bosnia-Herzegovina on July 1, which normally would make him ineligible to play in team's next game, but FIFA lifted his suspension for a match on Monday after US President Donald Trump intervened with Infantino on behalf of the 25-year-old striker.

European Parliament lawmakers Barry Andrews, Lara Wolters and Niels Fuglsang said in a joint statement that FIFAs decision to "change the rule on red card sus-



pensions mid-tournament is a disgrace and a perversion of justice."

"Once again, we've seen

Infantino and FIFA surrender to the demands of the Trump administration," the statement said. The lawmakers are asking the

national football associations of the EU countries to spur the FIFA Ethics Committee to investigate Infantino and whether pressure

FIFA HAS SAID THE LIFTING OF THE SUSPENSION WAS A DECISION OF A DISCIPLINARY PANEL

from the Trump administration was a factor in the lifting of the suspension, as well as "other potential breaches of political neutrality" like awarding Trump the FIFA Peace Prize.

FIFA has said the lifting of the suspension was a decision of a disciplinary committee.

The lawmakers said that 35 colleagues have so far signed the letter. "The beauty of sport is that it is based on impartial and transparent rules. When Infantino allows political pressure to determine who gets to play, this sense of fairness goes out the window," they said.

Ruben Vargas sends Switzerland to World Cup quarterfinals



ANNE M PETERSON ■ Vancouver (Canada)

In a match with few fireworks, the Swiss were patient against the Colombians and their enthusiastic fans.

After a scoreless draw, Ruben Vargas converted the decisive penalty and Switzerland advanced to the World Cup quarterfinals, beating Colombia 4-3 in a shootout on Tuesday.

Switzerland will face defending champion Argentina on Saturday at Arrowhead Stadium in Kansas City, Missouri. Argentina defeated Egypt 3-2 earlier in the day.

Switzerland had not reached the quarterfinals of a World Cup since hosting the tournament in 1954. And the Swiss were short-handed Tuesday without young midfielder Johan Manzambi, who was injured in training on Monday.

Vargas, who has scored two goals in the World Cup, also left Monday's training early but came on in stoppage time at the end of regulation.

In the shootout, Colombia defender Davinson Sanchez's penalty attempt hit the crossbar and Switzerland goalkeeper Gregor Kobel saved an attempt by Cucho Hernandez.

FIFA President Gianni Infantino was among those at BC Place, where the sellout crowd of 52,497 was overwhelmingly clad in yellow in support of Colombia.

"They had the crowd on their side, so it was a tough game for us," Kobel said. "We know we had some stretches of the game where we had to defend and stay strong mentally. Obviously we had a few players missing so, yeah, it was a big challenge for us."

Colombia failed to qualify for the last World Cup in 2022. Los Cafeteros made the quarterfinals at the 2014 tournament in Brazil, defeating Uruguay in the round of 16 before losing to the host country 2-1.

"The dream was enormous," Colombia midfielder John Arias said. "The country showed us that it believed in us, that it lived every moment with us, and I think that only makes the pain even greater." (AP)

Lionel Messi scores his eighth goal, takes lead in Golden Boot race

MAURA CAREY ■ Atlanta

Lionel Messi let the tears flow at the final whistle, succumbing to emotion after Argentina conjured up an incredible two-goal comeback to beat Egypt 3-2 on Tuesday and advance to the World Cup quarterfinals.

Argentina's three goals came in the final 11 minutes of regulation and injury time. Messi played a direct hand – or foot – in two of them.

Messi helped get Argentina on the board in the 79th minute, assisting on Cristian Romero's header. Four minutes later, he levelled the match at 2-2, drilling a shot past Egypt goalkeeper Mostafa Shobeir. A sold-out crowd at Mercedes-Benz Stadium, and no one was surprised it was Messi who paved the way to victory.

"Watching Leo run the way he does, just pushing himself further every day – I just told him that he deserved it. He's our role model, our guide – the one who helps us at all times," Argentina forward Lautaro Martinez said.



Djokovic outlasts Auger-Aliassime after more than 5 hours to reach Wimbledon semifinals at age 39

ANDREW DAMPF/KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

Side to side. Corner to corner. Novak Djokovic kept pushing Felix Auger-Aliassime back and forth along the Centre Court baseline at Wimbledon to retrieve one shot after another.

Finally, on the 22nd shot of a grueling rally deep in a fifth-set super tiebreaker, Auger-Aliassime had a forehand in the middle of the court. Under normal circumstances it might have been just the shot he was looking for.

Not this time. Not after five hours of battling with the 39-year-old Djokovic.

Auger-Aliassime, a 25-year-old Canadian with one of the top-rated forehands on tour, had nothing left in his tank. He sprayed his forehand wide to give Djokovic a 9-4 lead. Then both players bent over in exhaustion and leaned on their rackets. Djokovic, while he was bent over, still found energy to encourage the crowd to cheer louder, waving his right arm for more noise.

One point later, the longest quarterfinal in Wimbledon history – at 5 hours and 15 minutes – was finished. "These," Djokovic said, "are the kind of moments that I still play tennis for." Djokovic, the seven-time Wimbledon champion, prevailed 7-6 (10), 3-6, 6-3, 6-7 (4), 7-6 (4) on Tuesday to set up a semifinal against defending champion Jannik Sinner.

"I'm still able to battle these young guys that have 15 years less than me," Djokovic said. "I'm able to beat them at the tightest possible scoreline. ... In a sense, it is really a nice surprise. But at the same time, I always have the highest expectations for myself."



Djokovic continues to break records as he chases a 25th Grand Slam title. He's reached a record-setting eighth consecutive Wimbledon final four – moving him one ahead of Roger Federer for most consecutive men's singles semifinal appearances at the grass-court tournament.

"We know, because we've seen him so much, but it's so impressive that he does it time and time again," Auger-Aliassime said. The match ended just before the All England Club's 11 pm curfew took effect.

To celebrate, Djokovic raised his arms high and wide and took in the applause as he walked to the net to shake hands with Auger-Aliassime. Then Djokovic performed a little elbows-to-knees dance. He often mentions that his daughter, who was watching in the players' box, tries to teach him moves.

Later, Djokovic was asked to compare himself with another 39-year-old still performing at the

highest of levels: Lionel Messi of Argentina.

"It would be nice to play 90 minutes like him," Djokovic said of the soccer great.

Rematch with Sinner Sinner spent less than half the amount of time on court as Djokovic did when he beat Jan-Lennard Struff 7-5, 7-6 (4), 6-3 much earlier in the day on No. 1 Court.

Sinner beat Djokovic in straight sets in last year's Wimbledon semifinals; and Djokovic outlasted the Italian over five sets in the last four of this year's Australian Open.

"I wish it was finals, so I don't need to worry about how the body will feel tomorrow," Djokovic said. "I was telling the kids to go to sleep after the fourth (set) but they didn't want to listen. I'm glad they stayed because it was honestly one of the best matches I was part of on this court in my career."

Djokovic does get two days off before Friday's semifinals.

Medical time outLate in the first set, Djokovic dealt with what appeared to be a lower-leg issue. He took a medical time out and a trainer tested the stability of his left ankle and calf before massaging his calf muscle.

Djokovic had earlier leaned over to stretch his leg by pulling back the tip of his sneaker. He also stretched while standing at the back wall.

There was more stretching the rest of the way, too – especially late in the fifth set.

"It was really anybody's game in the super tiebreak in the fifth," Djokovic said.

Djokovic opposes roof closureDjokovic objected to the decision to close the Centre Court roof at 7:40 p.m. after Auger-Aliassime won the second set to level at a set apiece.

Djokovic told Wimbledon tournament referee Denise Parnell that they could squeeze in another set before the natural light faded.

(AP)



Grounded Preeti Pawar eyes CWG boxing gold

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ New Delhi

Nothing in life is certain and plans do not always work out the way one hopes. India's young boxer Preeti Pawar learnt that lesson early in her career, which is why she heads into Commonwealth Games with confidence from a stellar run of results but without taking anything for granted.

The 22-year-old bantamweight (54kg) boxer has emerged as one of India's brightest boxing prospects over the last three years, overcoming setbacks while steadily adding medals to her resume.

Making her senior World Championships debut in 2023, Preeti impressed despite bowing out in the pre-quarterfinals. She bounced back later that year by winning a bronze



medal at the Hangzhou Asian Games and securing a quota for the Paris Olympics.

Her Olympic campaign, however, was disrupted after she contracted Hepatitis A just before the Games. Despite the illness affecting her preparations, she still reached the Round of 16.

The experience has made her more measured in her outlook. "At the Commonwealth Games

I want to perform my best and get a medal for India...a gold. Let's see what will happen because sometimes we plan something but it doesn't go our way," Preeti said.

Following a long break after the Olympics, Preeti returned to international competition in style, winning gold at the 2025 World Boxing Cup Final before claiming silver at Boxam Elite International tournament in Spain. (PTI)

Tulika Maan eyes CWG gold to add to Birmingham silver



HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Commonwealth Games silver medalist judoka Tulika Maan, who made a first-round first-round exit at the Paris Olympics, is determined to put that disappointment behind and upgrade the colour of her medal in upcoming CWG in Glasgow.

Maan's Olympic campaign ended in heartbreaking fashion after she lost her opening women's +78kg bout to Cuban great Idalyis Ortiz in just 28 seconds in Paris Olympics two years back.

"Paris was like a black day for me," Maan told PTI on the sidelines of the Indian contingent's kit unveiling and send-off ceremony here.

"Making a comeback from there was very difficult because I knew the pressure was there. But it's okay. Because of my family, I am ready for the 2026 Commonwealth Games."

The Delhi judoka had

claimed silver in the +78kg category at the 2022 Commonwealth Games in Birmingham after going down in a hard-fought final to Scotland's Sarah Adlington.

Asked if she was looking to improve on that result, Maan made her intentions clear.

"Yes, for sure. It's not that I have to, I want to change it," she said. "Hopefully, I will win the gold. It will be a blessing for me because I will finally get the moment that I wanted in Birmingham."

Maan is set for another potential clash with Adlington in Glasgow, this time on the Scot's home turf, but the Indian is confident of not repeating the mistakes she made in the 2022 final. "Last time as well it was her home ground, but the mistakes were mine. I won't repeat them again."

"She is very experienced and I know what to expect. I am well prepared for that fight and really excited as well," she said. (PTI)

Prime Volleyball League gets FIVB recognition

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Prime Volleyball League has received world body FIVB's recognition as India's first division league for the sport and will return for its fifth season from November 30, the organisers announced on Wednesday.

The season 5 players' auction will be held in Goa on August 17 where franchises will assemble their squads for the upcoming season from a pool of India's top volleyball talent. "In a significant endorsement of its sustained growth and impact over the past four years, the Federation Internationale de Volleyball (FIVB) has officially recognised PVL as India's first division professional volleyball league," stated a press release from the league owners.

In addition, the clubs participating in Prime Volleyball League will be eligible to compete in international tournaments under the Central Asian Volleyball Association (CAVA), Asian Volleyball Confederation (AVC), and FIVB club competitions, subject to applicable regulations and qualification criteria. "This pathway creates new opportunities for Indian clubs to test themselves



against top teams across Asia and globally."

"Season 5 marks a defining moment for the Prime Volleyball League. The FIVB recognition is a strong validation of the work that has gone in over the last four years to build a credible, competitive, and globally relevant league," said Tuhin Mishra, MD and Co-Founder, Baseline Ventures and Director, Prime Volleyball League. "From the outset, the aim has been to build a league that delivers both sporting excellence and long-term impact."

Need to adapt better, reset will take time: Gautam Gambhir

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nottingham

India's T20 squad is in transition following a "reset", declared head coach Gautam Gambhir as he attributed the horrendous run in the ongoing tour of UK to an acute lack of game awareness and failure to read the conditions correctly.

India slumped to their heaviest-ever T20I defeat in terms of runs, losing by 125 to England in the third T20I on Tuesday. The visitors are now 0-2 down in the

five-match series. "We just haven't played well," Gambhir said at the post-match press conference here. "There are a lot of changes from the XI that played the T20 World Cup final to now. Be it the captain, be it the opening batsman. There is no Hardik Pandya, there is no Jasprit Bumrah," he pointed out. "When you go for that reset, it takes a bit of time. If you see, a 15-year-old (Sooryavanshi) is opening. Prince Yadav is in his second T20I, Harshit is back from an injury. We look only at results, results are important in international cricket, but we have to be practical," he added.

Back to normal conditions here: Archer

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nottingham

England pace spearhead Jofra Archer believes bowling in English conditions is a return to "normal" after playing on "easy wickets and smaller boundaries" in India particularly during the IPL.

Archer returned figures of 3/29 while fellow fast bowler Josh Tongue claimed 4/38 as India were skittled out for 76 in 11.4 overs while chasing 202 in the third T20I — their biggest defeat in terms of runs in the shortest format.

The defeat also left the revamped Indian side, led by Shreyas Iyer, still searching for their first T20I win after taking over from Suryakumar Yadav following the World Cup triumph in March.

"I think it goes back to normal here," Archer said at the post-match conference when asked how much his plans change while bowling to Indian batters after facing many of them in the IPL.

"You try to bowl the ball straight on a good length. Whereas over there, because the wickets are so easy and the boundaries are so small, you have to be really, really particular. Here, I feel your margin



for error is a little bit bigger."

He further said a total of 200-plus at Trent Bridge was always going to be difficult to chase unlike in the IPL, where such scores are often considered below par.

"At the IPL, sometimes 200 isn't safe. With 200 on the board on that wicket, I don't want to say we were confident, but I felt it would have taken a really special innings to chase it down. I'm just glad everybody chipped in. Everybody who

India look to stay afloat in T20I series against England



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bristol

Faced with selection dilemmas and struggling to adapt in hostile conditions, the Shreyas Iyer-led India have their task cut out when they take on England in the series-deciding fourth T20 International here on Thursday.

The biggest selection conundrum surrounds Sanju Samson, who was dropped from the second and third T20I in favour of 15-year-old swashbuckler Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. The teenager has not done any worse or better than the rest of the team so far and given that the side is trailing 0-2 right now, India head coach Gautam Gambhir has not ruled out Samson's return.

In a matter of four months, Samson's career has swung from darkness to dizzying heights, only to return to square one.

While it would be unfair to blame skipper Iyer, who is chasing his first victory since being elevated to captaincy in a surprise decision during his comeback series, the onus lies heavily on the coaching think-tank led by Gambhir and Ajit Agarkar's selection committee. It remains to be seen if they can avoid the ignominy of another series loss. The tactical calls made by the team management have not gone down well with the fans too.

Chants of "We Want Sanju" echoed outside Trent Bridge stadium as the Gambhir-led contingent proceeded to the

team bus following their crushing 125-run defeat in the third T20I on Wednesday.

If sidelining their T20 World Cup-winning skipper Suryakumar Yadav immediately after the historic triumph drew immense criticism, the decision to ignore hero of the same tournament, Samson, has now fuelled another public backlash.

The shocking capitulation at Trent Bridge has also laid bare the team's flaws and the management's lack of a clear vision. The batters failed miserably against a fast and furious pace attack led by Jofra Archer and Josh Tongue, who blew India away by sharing seven wickets between them, including the entire top five.



Samson has been given clarity on his omission, says Gambhir

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nottingham

India head coach Gautam Gambhir asserted that Sanju Samson has been given complete clarity about his role after being dropped from the playing XI and did not rule out a comeback for the wicketkeeper-batter in the ongoing T20I series against England. Samson has also been omitted from the squad for the upcoming tour of Zimbabwe. Gambhir maintained that the senior player remains in India's plans in the five-match series, which the visitors trail 0-2 after two losses and a washout.

"The clarity that should have been given to Sanju Samson, he has got from me," Gambhir said after India's 125-run defeat in the third T20I here on Tuesday. "And that conversation is between a head coach and a player. The contents of that conversation are obviously not something I'll share with you."

"...we are absolutely clear that what Sanju has done for India,



especially during the World Cup, has been phenomenal. Sometimes, though, you also have to look at the form of a certain player. There is no hard and fast rule that he cannot make a comeback in this series."

Samson, who was adjudged Player of the Tournament at this year's T20 World Cup, was replaced in the playing XI by 15-year-old batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi after scores of 5, 0 and 1 in his last three innings against Ireland and in the series-opener against England.

Our performance was atrocious and unacceptable: Shreyas Iyer



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nottingham

India captain Shreyas Iyer minced no words after his team's crushing 125-run defeat to England in the third T20 International, describing the performance as "atrocious" and admitting such a heavy loss was "not acceptable".

Under Iyer, India are yet to win a T20 International, and Tuesday's outing marked an abject surrender as they were bowled out for 76 in just 11.4 overs while chasing 202 to suffer their biggest defeat in the

format in terms of runs.

"It was atrocious, losing by that margin is not acceptable. First things first, we have to accept the loss and go back to drawing board," Iyer said at the post-match presentation ceremony.

The win handed England an unassailable 2-0 lead in the five-match series ahead of the fourth T20I in Bristol on Thursday and the final in Southampton on Saturday. The opening match was a washout. Iyer felt that the bowling unit shouldn't have gone for 200 on this Trent Bridge track.

IOC eases path toward Russia returning with full team at 2028 LA Olympics

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ GENEVA

Russia has moved closer toward having a full team with its national flag and anthem at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

The International Olympic Committee on Tuesday provisionally lifted a suspension of the Russian Olympic Committee and advised Olympic sports bodies to end a three-year program where Russian athletes had to be vetted for permission to compete as neutrals. The IOC said the timing was because qualifying events are starting for the L.A. Games, and "the need to offer equal access to these competitions to all athletes."

The move, which also signals a return for Russia in team sports, had been expected since the IOC advised two months ago that athletes from Belarus, which was Russia's ally when its military invasion of Ukraine started in 2022, should be allowed again to compete with their full national identity. "We don't want to hold



athletes accountable for the actions of their governments," IOC president Kirsty Coventry said at an online news conference after she chaired an executive board meeting. A two-time Olympic gold medalist swimming for Zimbabwe, Coventry said it was a fair decision and noted: "I wouldn't be sitting here if I had to pay the price when my country was going through things and being sanctioned."

Ukraine's sports minister Matvi Bidnyi questioned why the IOC

altered its rules when in the war "nothing changed. The situation became even worse."

Russia unleashed waves of missiles and drones at Ukraine early Monday, killing at least 22 people. "So we don't understand it," Bidnyi told The Associated Press in an interview Tuesday. "In this day, when all of Ukraine (is) in a day of mourning, when our flags was a little bit lower because of so many people, our peaceful citizens was killed yesterday at night."